the center for
deliberative democracy
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Deliberative Democracy in the Classroom Toolkit Instructions

This toolkit is intended for high-school students, and will complement classes in History or Government. This toolkit is designed for 4 class sessions of about an hour per session. All components can be a shortened or lengthened to fit existing curriculum.

This Toolkit should be used accompanied with:

1. Citizenship in 21st Century America – Complete Briefing Materials – Teachers' Copy
2. Citizenship in 21st Century America – Briefing Materials with Worksheets – Student Copy
    a. Topic 1: Citizenship and Participation
    b. Topic 2: Exercising Choice
    c. Topic 3: Serving One's Country
    d. Topic 4: Becoming Informed
3. Pre-deliberation Baseline Survey for Citizenship in 21st Century America
4. Post-deliberation Survey for Citizenship in 21st Century America
5. One-page moderator guide for student moderators

Overview

The public is generally ill informed – for quite understandable reasons – about most issues of public interest. Yet, individuals are still expected to provide an "opinion" when asked for one in public opinion polls. These polls supposedly provide us with a glimpse of what the public thinks right here and now. However, we may want to reconsider the extent to which the results of these polls accurately reflect the public's true opinions and beliefs given the lack of awareness about the issues. Deliberative Polling seeks to obtain public opinion that is not only representative, but also considered and well thought-out.

The *Deliberative Democracy in the Classroom Toolkit* is inspired by an innovative public consultation method known as Deliberative Polling®. The process in the classroom will begin and end with students' opinions about a critical issue on the national, statewide or local civic agenda. The Center for Deliberative Democracy, in partnership with PBS *By the People*, has prepared a set of materials for the classroom titled **Citizenship in 21st Century America**. These materials are based on an actual Deliberative Poll that was held online with a national sample of the US population. These classroom materials include vetted balanced briefing materials and pre- and post-deliberation surveys. In addition, this toolkit has built in classroom time for students to research facts and perspectives on the issues, learn to locate, consider, and verify alternative and independent sources, engage in critical thinking by weighing competing arguments, and critically assess their premises and sources of information. Active classroom or school-wide discussion in moderated settings in small groups and large groups brings civic debate to life. At the conclusion of the Deliberative Democracy activity, the participating students answer the same "opinion poll" they did at the start and are able to track how their own and peers' thinking evolved with further knowledge, research, critical thinking and civic engagement.

Purpose

The Deliberative Democracy in the Classroom Toolkit combines civic education with exercises in critical thinking, collaboration, and research that buttress language arts' reading, understanding and reasoning

classroom imperatives though vetted briefing discussion materials as well as vetted Internet destinations, online search and information and sources verification opportunities, and activities synced to the Common Core standards.

Objectives

1. To introduce students to the concept of "Deliberative Polling"
2. To help students build research skills necessary for becoming well informed on specific topics as well as citizens more generally.
3. To undergo "civic engagement" through discussion with peers in order to become more knowledgeable about competing perspectives on a specific topic of discussion.
4. To track how thinking evolves with further knowledge, research, critical thinking, and civic engagement.

Session 1 – Introduction to Deliberative Polling

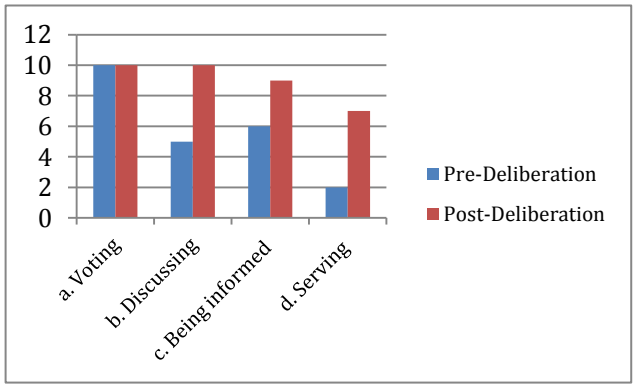
Purpose: The goal of this session is to get students comfortable with the idea of "Deliberative Polling" and how it is different from the typical polling process.

Learning Objectives:
1. Learning how to use Excel for data input and analysis
2. Become familiar with the concept of public opinion
3. Begin discovering the importance of citizen voice in public affairs.

Activities:
1. Warm-up (15 minutes):
   a) Hand out the pre-deliberation survey on *Citizens in 21st Century America* from the CDD website.
   b) If done on paper, assign "student numbers" to each student, so the survey remains anonymous. Keep the numbers until the entire activity is done, to compare changes at the individual level.

Something to consider: Surveys, exercise in Data Entry.
If the surveys are completed on paper, you may arrange for students enter their own survey data into Microsoft Excel. This way, students can see their opinions from their surveys graphically in Excel. Please refer to the Data Entry Instructions worksheet for more detailed steps.

	A	B	C
1	1. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think each of the following is to being a good citizen?	Pre-Deliberation	Post-Deliberation
2	a. Voting in elections	10	10
3	b. Discussing politics with others	5	10
4	c. Being informed about politics and political issues	6	9
5	d. Serving one's country through military or public service	2	7
6			
7	2. How strongly would you favor or oppose each of the following?		
8	a. Making Election Day a national holiday	2	8



Alternatively, you can have your students complete the survey online, prior to coming to class, as their homework. This way, there is no need for data entry and the online survey tool will create helpful graphical results. Please contact the Center at cdd@dp.stanford.edu for a personalized link.

2. Discussion and Lecture (35 minutes)
   a) Prompt discussion with questions about public opinion. Some questions are provided below:

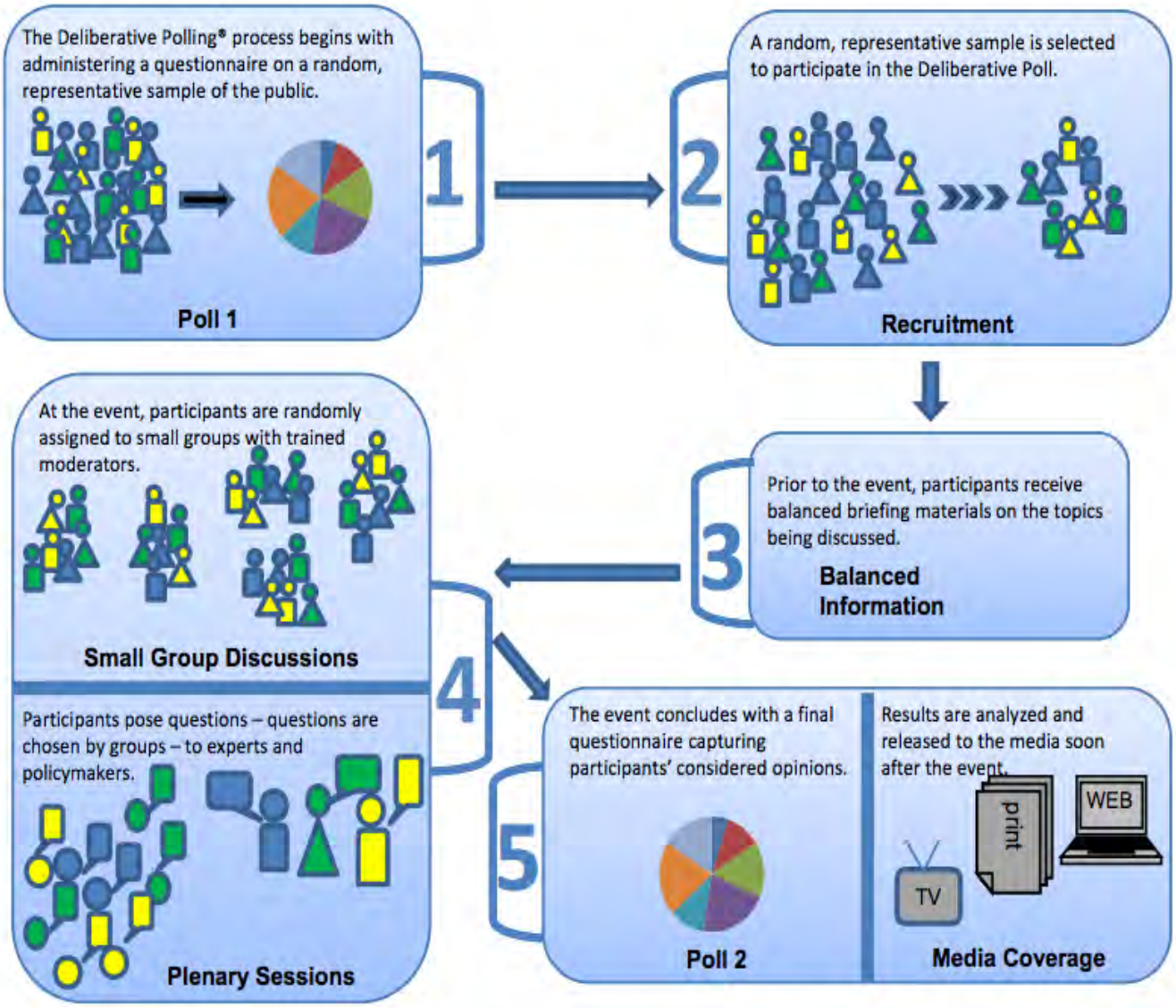
What are surveys?	What is polling?
Do you think that the decisions you voiced in the survey were reflective of your opinions?	How did you feel responding to survey questions that you did not know very much about?

b) Then, you can provide a definition of polling and explain how polling is done in the community.

- Conventional polling is conducted everyday and on almost any topic.
- Polling firms will usually conduct surveys through telephone and random digit dialing.
- Surveys are usually conducted for people over 18, so high school students may not have participated in telephone surveys.
- Survey companies are beginning to conduct surveys over mobile phones—some firms even use text messages
- Internet polling, like CNN instant polls, is becoming more common.
- Some polls do not use random selection, so they focus on getting the opinion of a certain group of people.

c) Begin a discussion of deliberative polling and contrast it with the initial discussion of polling.

Here is a brief description of deliberative polling:



Here are some places that deliberative polling has been conducted:

National Projects. CDD and MacNeil/Lehrer Productions have conducted DPs on issues facing the citizens of the US such as foreign policy, health care, education, and citizenship in the 21st century.

European Union. CDD and its European collaborators conducted the first European-wide DP with more than 360 randomly selected citizens from all 27 member states and discussions were conducted in 23 languages.

State and Local Projects. Energy Choices - Vermont, Nebraska, Texas (8 projects) and Nova Scotia have used DP to give guidance on how their state/province should meet its future electricity needs.

China. Zeguo Township in Zhejiang Province has conducted three DPs - allowing residents to impact the budgetary decisions of their local government.

And, here are some of the effects of deliberative polling:

- After the Bulgarian project (May 2007), Prime Minister Stanishev publicly embraced the results and pledged to implement the policy recommendations toward the Roma and even followed up by commissioning another national Deliberative Poll on budget priorities.
- The Northern Ireland DP (February 2007) on school collaboration also seems like it has led to policy consequences for shared schooling.
- The Zeguo Township DP (2005) influenced the budget of the town, with the town putting into effect the top projects citizens voted on in the poll.

Finally, here is a chart that compares the deliberative polling process and the classroom toolkit process:

Toolkit	Both	Deliberative Polling
• Shortened to fit into time constraints of average high school class • Adjusted to complement a high school curriculum • Students take on the role of many parts of the deliberative polling process, such as researching pros and cons to form "briefing materials." • Students act as moderators in small group discussions • Students become experts in the panel sessions	• Based on Deliberative Polling • Help strengthens civic education and citizenship • Provides place for discussion about important issues • Allows citizens to think about and reflect upon their opinions	• Often a multi-day activity • Scientifically selected people to be demographically representative through phone surveys, versus having a classroom's students • Briefing materials are created beforehand by experts • Moderators are provided for small group discussions • Experts answer questions during the panel sessions

3. Finishing up (10 minutes):
   a) As a class, brainstorm other topics that call for a deliberative poll in your community/campus. (Consider issues big and small. For example, how should school funds be appropriated on campus? Or should healthcare be required for all citizens?).

   (Optional) Explain how the next 3 class sessions will be conducted, providing students with a general idea about what they will be expected to do as part of this 4 session deliberative polling activity. Allow time for any questions that the students may have for questions about today's lesson, the deliberative polling activity, or deliberative polling in general.

Session 2 – Building News and Digital Literacy Research

Purpose-To research arguments related to citizenship and become informed before small group discussions.

Learning Objectives:
1. Help students build research skills through the web and/or through texts.
2. Help students become proficient at reading documents for arguments and supporting evidence.
3. Aid students in assessing the validity of sources.
4. Allow students to analyze both sides of controversial issues.

Activities:
1. Assigning groups. For this Toolkit, there are four possible topics: Citizenship and Participation, Exercising Choice, Serving One's Country, and Becoming Informed. Please assign your students to groups following one of the following ways:

A. If you assign your entire class to one topic…	B. If you split your class into four groups…	C. If you split your class into two groups…
• All students in your class can research and discuss the same topic. • Students can compare and contrast their research results • You can focus each class session on a different topic. • If you use all four topics, you will need four class sessions to cover all four topics.	• Each group can discuss one topic • All four topics can be completed in one sessions • Students can learn about topics from each other	• Each group discusses one topic of the four for two topics total covered • There is still variety in the students' research topics, but more than one topic can be covered • You can have another session for the other two topics. • If you use all four topics, you will need two class sessions to cover all the topics.

2. Issue and read discussion materials (20 minutes)
   a) The materials are titled **Citizenship in 21st Century America** and are downloadable from the CDD website.

3. Fill-in the Pro/Con arguments worksheets (40 minutes)
   a) This task can be a homework assignment or a classroom group assignment, individually or in groups. Afterward, students can combine their charts into a final class chart.
   b) The worksheets are available for download on the CDD website.
   c) These Pro/Con argument worksheets will be the basis for small group discussion, next class.

Deliberative Democracy in the Classroom Toolkit

The following section was prepared by Professor Geanne Rosenberg, Director of the Harnisch Collaborative Future of Journalism Projects at Baruch College of the City University of New York and Faculty Associate at Harvard University's Berkman Center for Internet & Society.

Here are suggested ways to building News and Digital Literacy:

It is important to find credible information online while building the Pro/Con Argument worksheets. Here are some exercises to aid in finding reliable research:

1. Lesson in Search Parameters and Key Words:

- What are the best keywords for finding information about citizenship?
- What are the worst?
- What is the difference in the results?
- What Google search parameters and advanced techniques can help improve the results? Let students play around with Google Advanced Search, available at: http://www.google.ca/advanced_search
- Individuals or groups can report their findings in terms of best and worst methods to the class.

2. Lesson in Researching Complex Issues Online, Finding Credible Sources and Verification Strategies Part I:

- Who can find the most important and accurate facts about the citizenship?
- What were the steps?
- How can you verify the information and prove it is accurate? Factors include whether it is a .edu, .gov, .com or .net site, looking up the authors' credentials, and double-checking the facts presented on the site.
- One possibility here is to break the students up into workgroups on different aspects of citizenship – perhaps in the four topics suggested above.

3. Lesson in Researching Complex Issues Online, Finding Credible Sources and Verification Strategies Part II.

Egyptians celebrating in Tahrir Square after the fall of Mubarak

- How do we build citizenship?
- What are examples from other countries? What should the expectations be?
- Ask the students to discover for themselves what data is accurate or misleading. How can they tell? How can they verify or debunk?
- Questions for Class Discussion: Do they consider the accuracy of the information they share in their social networking activities? Do they think about the accuracy of the information shared by others?

Wrapping Up

At the end of this class session, your students will have completed their worksheets for the next class session's group discussion. In preparation for next class session, the small group discussions, you will need to:

a) Split the class into groups of 8-10 people.
   i) There are two additional roles that should be assigned:

The Moderator: Moderators facilitate group discussion so it is balanced in both the number of people talking and the type of arguments presented.

- There is one moderator per small group
- Please hand them the *One Page Guide for Moderators of Small Group Discussions,* available on the CDD website. Moderators should ensure that the guidelines are followed in discussion.
- Some general guidelines for discussion are: Everyone's voice counts, Respect and listen to each other's opinions, Not everyone needs to agree or disagree. Moderators should not express their own opinions or biases, and ensure that participants are talking to each other, and not them.

The Expert: Experts answer questions during the panel sessions with more in-depth information.

- There should be three to five experts per topic. These students do not participate in small-group discussions, but can listen.
- The experts should be students who are familiar with their arguments and sources of information.
- You can pick different experts for different topics, so students who are experts may participate in other topics' discussions on different days of class.
- Alternatively, you could have real experts come in for the panel discussions.

Alternatively, you could have actual experts come in—for example, the Government teacher, local officials, and others who work with government and citizenship

b) Ask all students think of some questions that they want to ask the panelists in class tomorrow.

Session 3 – Deliberative Democracy

Purpose: To undergo "deliberative democracy" through discussion with peers. This will be executed in two parts: first, small groups for discussions and second, a large "panel" discussion.

Learning Objectives:
1. Consider multiple points of view on a specific topic
2. Learn how to formulate educated opinions with supporting evidence

Here are three suggestions for arranging your class in accordance with suggestions made in session two:

A. If you assigned your entire class to one topic…	B. If you split your class into four groups…	C. If you split your class into two groups…
• Hold the discussions for one topic at a time. • You will need four class sessions if you want to cover all four topics.	• Hold discussions for all four topics in one session. • If you want the entire class to observe all four discussions, the discussions for each topic will only be about 15 minutes. • Alternatively, you could split the class into four groups and have them hold their own discussions for the whole class period, and then have them share later.	• Have two class sessions, where the 1st class session cover two topics and the 2nd class session cover the remaining two topics. • Please adjust the time allotted for the sessions below accordingly.

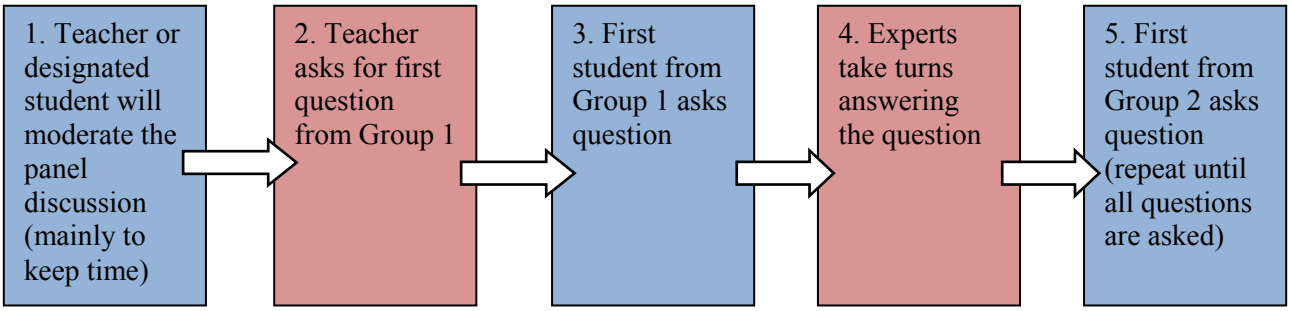
Activities

1. <u>Small Group Discussions</u> (*40 minutes*)
   a) Designate the roles of moderator and experts. There is one moderator per group, and two to three experts per topic.
   b) Begin the group discussions!
      - You should have about 8-10 students in each group.
      - Have the moderator begin the discussions as described above. Please hand them the one-paged moderator guide for reference.
   c) About 5 minutes prior to your designated end time, have groups come up with two questions to ask the "experts" during the panel discussion. These questions need to be agreed upon by the entire group. The groups should designate students to ask the questions.

2. <u>Panel Discussion</u> (*15 minutes*)
   a) Organize the classroom so that the "experts" form a panel at the front of the class. The "experts" will only respond to questions developed from the small group discussions. Panelists should be allowed to have their sources and any other materials they want to reference as they speak and answer questions.
   b) All panelists should have the opportunity to answer each question, but answers should be limited to 2-3 minutes per panelist.

c) Teachers should emphasize that no one can "win" the discussion. It is not a debate in which there is a winner and loser. Instead, all students (on the panel and not!) should feel encouraged to listen to and absorb the multiple points of view on that particular topic.

Suggested Format for Panel Discussion



3. Wrapping it up (*5 minutes*)
   a) Go over the points that students found most convincing on both sides of the argument.
   b) Remind students that in the next and final session they will be asked for their opinions on the topic again and that students should consider all the viewpoints that were voiced in the discussions today when making their decisions.

Session 4 – Wrap up and Final Survey

Purpose: To complete the deliberative poll and measure any changes.

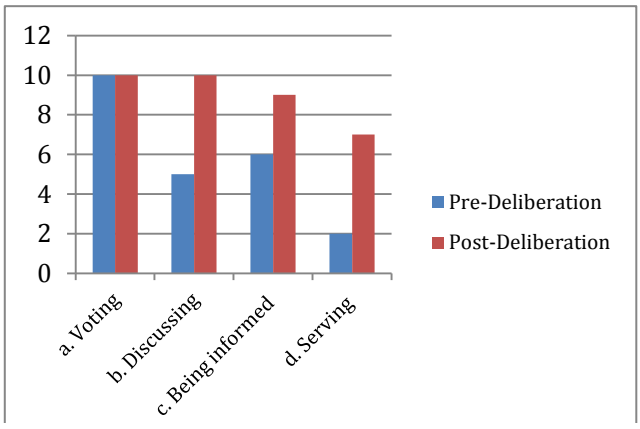
Learning Objectives:
1. Track how thinking evolves with further knowledge, research, critical thinking, and civic engagement.
2. Analyze changes graphically and through Excel.

Activities
1. Administer the post deliberation survey (*15 minutes*)
   a) The full survey should be taken in silence and should be anonymous. Please assign the students the same numbers they had when they filled out the first survey. This survey can be completed on paper in class or online. If online, please contact cdd@dp.stanford.edu for a personalized link.

2. Show the results from the first survey graphically (*15 minutes*)
   a) As a class, discuss these results.
   b) Examine the second survey results, and how they differ from the first survey results.
      - If taken online, the results from the second survey should be available immediately through the online software. If taken on paper, results may be input by the students themselves as an exercise in data entry.
   c) The answers to the knowledge questions are provided below, to measure if there have been any knowledge gains throughout the activity.

Something to consider: Surveys, exercise in Data Entry.
If the surveys are completed on paper, you may arrange for students enter their own survey data into Microsoft Excel. This way, students can see their opinions from their surveys graphically in Excel. Please refer to the Data Entry Instructions worksheet for more detailed steps.

	A	B	C
1	1. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think each of the following is to being a good citizen?	Pre-Deliberation	Post-Deliberation
2	a. Voting in elections	10	10
3	b. Discussing politics with others	5	10
4	c. Being informed about politics and political issues	6	9
5	d. Serving one's country through military or public service	2	7
6			
7	2. How strongly would you favor or oppose each of the following?		



Answers to the Pre- and Post- Survey Knowledge Questions

19. 5,000,000
20. Ensure a majority for one party over another
21. 50%
22. Australia
23. Men between 18 and 25 year old
24. Gets a majority of Electoral College votes
25. Every 10 years
26. Iowa and New Hampshire

3. Discussion and wrap up (*30 minutes*)
   a) Ask students to volunteer to explain why they did or did not change their opinions.
   b) Reflect on the deliberative polling process. Ask students if they feel better about their decision-making after learning about the topic or why being informed is beneficial not only for themselves as individuals, but also for society more generally.
   c) Summarize the key things that were learned throughout the process.
      - Explain that this does not have to be a one-time experience – being informed about various topics is doable.
      - Emphasize how students can go about learning more about any topics that interest them in the future by using resources online and at school.
      - Summarize ideas about what resources were most helpful for them (specific websites, books, people, etc.)

You can find more information on the methodology of Deliberative Polling(r) on the website of the **Center for Deliberative Democracy**: http://cdd.stanford.edu/

The contributors to this toolkit include:

- The Center for Deliberative Democracy at Stanford University,
- Ed Madison, Graduate Teaching Fellow at University of Oregon's School of Journalism and Communication
- Professor Geanne Rosenberg, Director of the Harnisch Collaborative Future of Journalism Projects at Baruch College of the City University of New York and Faculty Associate at Harvard University's Berkman Center for Internet & Society,
- Esther Wojcicki, Vice-Chair of the Creative Commons Board of Directors and Board Chair of Learning Matters
- Daniel Werner, former President of MacNeil/Lehrer Productions (PBS); Executive Producer of MacNeil/Lehrer Productions; Executive Producer of *By the People*

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By the People

Citizenship in 21st Century America

The United States is a **representative democracy**, in which government officials are selected by the people they represent. However, many have questioned whether democracy in the U.S. is working as it should. Almost half of those eligible to vote do not do so in presidential elections (even fewer participate in lower-level elections), and studies have found that many Americans do not have even basic knowledge about their elected representatives or the workings of our government.

> **Representative Democracy:** a form of government where citizens vote for officials to represent their desires indirectly in the government

Today's citizens are faced with a very different world than that of the Founding Fathers who established our democracy. Our country is much larger and communication is different than it was when the United States began. Instead of a small, mostly rural society of some three million people, we now have close to 300 million, mostly urban and suburban, residents. Instead of sending letters from Virginia to Boston that had to go by boat to England and then back again to America, we are all instantaneously connected electronically (through the internet and cell phones) and physically (by airplanes). Instead of just 30,000 people in a Congressional District, we are now approaching 800,000. In the modern United States, election campaigns are conducted through mass media rather than by grassroots

and are controlled by highly skilled political strategists. Although the internet and 24-hour news organizations may make political information more readily available, there is frequently an emphasis on who is ahead in the polls at the moment or on candidates' personal lives rather than on policy matters.

Suppose we have a society of "spectator citizens," who do little and are not involved in their democracy. Does it matter if people do not exercise any real choices, do not know much about politics and policy and do little in the way of public service or patriotism? Why? What must individual citizens do to make our democracy work? And what, if anything, can they reasonably be expected to do given the other pressures their daily lives? These are issues for our discussion.

We will focus on four paths of citizen involvement in government: participating in politics, exercising choice, serving one's country and becoming informed. In each case, there are different views ideas zabout the kinds of institutions and policies we might need—provided that each activity is something we think citizens in a democracy should do. In each case, we can ask: are these requirements of citizenship? Or might we decide that they are not really matters of public concern?

Citizenship and Participation

Some people think that the first duty of a citizen is to participate in politics. In representative democracies, election time is the key moment for citizens to express their preferences and influence how their country is governed. If a citizen does not vote, he or she gives up that influence. When failure to vote is a result of citizen disengagement or some deliberate effort to decrease the number of voters, an election with low turnout is unlikely to produce an accurate representation of the will of the people. And since those who do not vote tend to be demographically different from those that do (e.g. poor people are less likely to vote than wealthier people, young people less likely than old people), groups that do not vote may have less influence on policy outcomes.

America has one of the lowest rates of voter participation of any democracy in the world. Even in a presidential election, only about half the eligible voters turn out. In the presidential primary process and in state and local elections, the participation rate is much lower: in the single digits in some cases.

What factors contribute to our low voter turnout? Some argue that our election laws themselves make it more difficult for people to participate. For example, Election Day is usually on a weekday (the first Tuesday in November for presidential and congressional elections), and it may be difficult for people to get away from work to vote. To make voting easier, some states allow citizens to cast "early votes" in the run up to Election Day and/or to cast "absentee" votes by mail. However, other states do not have such measures in place, and critics argue that this is unfair because it makes it more difficult for some citizens to vote than others. Some suggest that Election Day should be a national holiday so that citizens in all states would have an equal and increased opportunity to vote.

In many states, furthermore, it is necessary to register weeks before Election Day in order to be eligible to vote. Critics point out that, since citizen awareness of campaigns and elections reaches its peak just shortly before Election Day, many citizens might not even be aware of an upcoming election at the time of the voter registration deadline. People who forget or don't have time or do not realize they need to register by the deadline then cannot have their votes counted on Election Day. Several states in the U.S. allow voters to register on Election Day itself, and these states tend to have significantly higher turnout than states that do not allow Election Day registration.

A more direct reduction in participation is brought about by laws in many states that bar convicted criminals from the political process. 48 states do not allow citizens in prison for a felony to vote, and it is illegal in the majority of states for felons who are on parole or probation to vote. Even after they have completed their sentences, convicted felons in some states are not allowed to vote. About five million Americans are unable to participate in elections for these reasons.

> **Swing State:** A state that could potentially be won by either a Democrat or a Republican

Some argue that our political institutions themselves discourage voter participation. The system means that only so-called **"swing states"** are in play in presidential elections. It is

The most recent Electoral College result s

assumed, for example, that California's **Electoral College** votes will always go to the Democratic candidate. Thus both Democrats and Republicans in California have less incentive to vote; some Democrats may not bother voting because they think they are going to win anyway, and some Republicans may not bother because they assume they are going to lose. Candidates tend to give little attention to states that have safe majorities of one party or the other and instead focus their campaign resources on the "swing states" where they might sway enough voters to move that state into their o wn Electoral College camp. This means that perhaps 22 states out of 50 are likely to experience serious campaigning and television advertising, while voters in other states are left as second-hand observers to campaigns in which the ads are not even shown in their states. Voters in non-swing states therefore experience lower voter turnout. Without the Electoral College, Republicans in California and Democrats in the Deep South would be part of the presidential campaign in the general election.

Electoral College: the system by which US presidents are elected; if a candidate wins the majority of votes in a state, he or she would win ALL of that state's electoral college votes; because of the Electoral College, it is possible to get a minority of the popular vote and still win the election

Other countries have found more direct ways to ensure high voter turnout, such as making voting required by law. In Australia, citizens who do not vote are subject to paying a fine and in Belgium, repeated failure to vote can lead to having your right to vote permanently canceled. These required voting laws do result in higher turnout: Australia and Belgium average over 90%. 32 countries currently have some kind of compulsory voting law.

On the other hand, there are those who say that low levels of voter participation are not worrisome. We have relatively respectable levels of participation from those who are registered to vote, they argue. It is just that, unlike most countries, we put the burden of registration entirely on the individual (in many other countries, voters are automatically registered by the government). If citizens do not even bother to register, then why should we be concerned about their votes? If people can't take the time to register, how informed or involved could they be in the campaign? According to this view, we should not be concerned about the preferences of those who cannot make even a minimal effort to get to the polls once every year or two.

And of course, it must be recognized that voting is not the only form of political participation. Showing up at rallies, writing letters to public officials such as members of congress, contributing to campaigns, or even just discussing one's political views might all be considered forms of political participation. In this regard, the spread of the web has dramatically increased opportunities for political participation (consider the massive number of political blogs, for example, or the success of online political organizing tools).

Discussion Questions

- What are the benefits of a representative democracy as compared to a direct democracy?
- Is it important to be informed about the government or election campaigns? Why or why not?
- How do election laws impact the number of people and the kinds of people that turn out to vote?
- Does the Electoral College make elections more or less fair?
- If you were 18, would you vote? On what information would you base your decision?

Some Proposals:

The chart below has some arguments for and against the following proposals. Have students research on their own or in groups to fill out their own charts.

	Approaches: Citizenship and Participation	
	Arguments for	**Arguments against**
Increase voter participation by making Election Day a national holiday.	• Having Election Day on a workday makes it very difficult for people to find time to vote. • Having it on a workday disadvantages the poor because they are most likely to be unable to afford time off work to make it to the polls.	• National holidays are very expensive because of lost economic productivity. • We already have enough national holidays. • If people really want to vote, they will find the time.
Increase voter participation by allowing Election Day registration	• Pre-Election Day registration establishes unnecessary bureaucratic barriers to political participation. • Voting should not be dependent on ability to jump through bureaucratic hoops.	• Requiring voter registration before Election Day helps to prevent voter fraud by making sure that only people who are truly eligible get to vote.
Increase voter participation by allowing felons to vote after they have served their sentences	• Convicted criminals who have served their sentences have already paid their debt to society; they should be allowed to once again enjoy the full benefits and responsibilities of citizenship.	• Convicted felons have shown that they are incapable of behaving as responsible citizens; permanently removing their votes is an appropriate punishment.
Increase voter participation by abolishing the Electoral College and substituting direct election of the president by popular vote	• The Electoral College is undemocratic as it makes some people's votes (e.g. residents of small states) weigh more than others'. • Switching to direct election by popular vote would make everyone's votes equal and remove the disincentive for people in "safe" states to vote.	• This is not a realistic option as it would require a constitutional amendment, and could not be accomplished for many years – if ever. • Small states enjoy disproportionate influence because of the Electoral College and they are unlikely to give up their current advantage.

	• Abolishing the Electoral College would also force candidates to appeal to voters in all states instead of being able to ignore those states they consider "safe."	• The United States is a federal coalition and should assign a value to the collective opinion of each state.
Increase voter participation by switching to "compulsory voting," with fines or other penalties for those that don't comply	• Voting is an obligation of citizenship and our laws should reflect this. • Compulsory voting helps to ensure that the elected government represents the will of *all* the people. • Compulsory voting helps to prevent the disenfranchisement of certain segments of society, such as poor people.	• Voting is a right, not an obligation, of citizenship. • People should still be free to choose whether or not to meet that obligation; compulsory voting is antithetical to democratic notions of personal liberty.
It is not necessary to increase voter turnout; low turnout is not a problem for a democracy	• If people do not bother to vote, we can assume that they do not care about the outcome of the election, so neither they nor society lose anything as a result of their not voting. • People who have no interest in or knowledge of politics should have no hand in choosing our government • Voting is not the only form of political participation, so people can be "good citizens" even without voting.	• High voter turnout is necessary to ensure the legitimacy of electoral outcomes. • Often, people fail to vote not because they do not care, but because candidates have not reached out to them effectively or because they lack the time/resources to make it to the polls. These people are still important members of society whose voices need to be heard.

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By the People

Exercising Choice

From this perspective, the central duty of citizens is not just to show up, it is also to exercise choice. The essence of democracy is that the public makes collective choices and the duty of each citizen is to take part in those decisions. But choices can only be made from among the available options, and it is hard for individual citizens to exercise choice if elections are not competitive. If the results are already decided beforehand, why should we expect voters to spend a lot of time and trouble registering their preferences? This view therefore emphasizes not just the role of citizens, but the context within which they must play that role. We need to have elections where there is enough competition for citizens to realize that their participation can make a difference. When parties compete, voters win. With competition, the voters can hold elected officials accountable; if voters have no real alternatives to the status quo, they have no way to register their disapproval of incompetence, corruption, or poor policy choices (or reward the opposite).

The United States essentially has a two-party system. Although this is not required by the Constitution, it is encouraged by our "**first-past-the-post**" voting system, by our non-parliamentary government, and by ballot access laws that set high barriers to entry into the electoral process (e.g. requiring the collection of large numbers of signatures to be eligible to run).

First-past-the-post: the candidate who gets the most votes is elected, even if they don't reach a 50% majority

Some people argue that there is little difference between the Democratic and Republican parties, and that we need to encourage the inclusion of candidates representing a broader range of policy positions. In this view, both Democratic and

Republican candidates rush to the middle in order to appeal to the greatest number of voters, thus leaving no real choices for people whose beliefs are further to the left or to the right on the political spectrum.

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Republican candidates rush to the middle in order to appeal to the greatest number of voters, thus leaving no real choices for people whose beliefs are further to the left or to the right on the political spectrum.

One way to increase the range of candidates would be to switch to a "**proportional representation**" voting system, some version of which is used in most major democracies.

> **Proportional representation:** the number of seats won by a party matches the number of votes that it received.

These systems seek to provide a close match between the percentage of votes that a party receives in an election and the number of seats they are given in the governing body. To illustrate: imagine an area called Citizenville that has a total of five congressional districts; 40% of voters in Citizenville are Democrats, 40% are Republicans, and 20% are supporters of the Alternative Party. Under our current first-past-the-post voting system, each of Citizenville's five districts has a separate election to choose its own representative. In Citizenville District 1, 41% of the vote in this election goes to the Republican, 39% to the Democrat, and 20% to the Alternative; the Republican is elected and 59% of District 1's voters have no one in Congress that represents their views. Similar outcomes occur in Citizenville Districts 2, 3, 4, and 5, so Citizenville elects five Republicans.

Under proportional representation, Citizenville would most likely elect two Democrats, two Republicans, and one Alternative. Citizenville's citizens would have three viable candidates to choose from instead of just two, and every citizen would have at least one official in Congress to represent his or her views. Proportional representation is currently in use in a small number of local electoral contexts (e.g. for school boards or city councils) around the U.S., but proponents would like to see it used in state and even federal elections.

Others have suggested that an easier way to increase electoral choice for American voters would be to reduce the barriers to ballot access that are currently in place and that often put third party candidates at a major disadvantage. In many states, the candidates of the major parties are automatically given a place on the ballot, while third party candidates have to go through a time- and resource-consuming process of signature collection to qualify. Critics argue that these measures solidify the powerful positions of the two major parties and make it difficult for third parties to break into the process.

On the other hand, some people feel that the two-party system provides plenty of choice for American voters. They point out that, unlike in many other democracies, American elected officials typically have wide choice to vote as they (or their constituents) please regardless of their party affiliation. For example, while the Democratic Party as a whole may have a reputation of being pro-choice, there are certainly Democratic representatives that are against abortion; likewise, while the Republican Party overall may be against gun control, some elected Republicans vote in

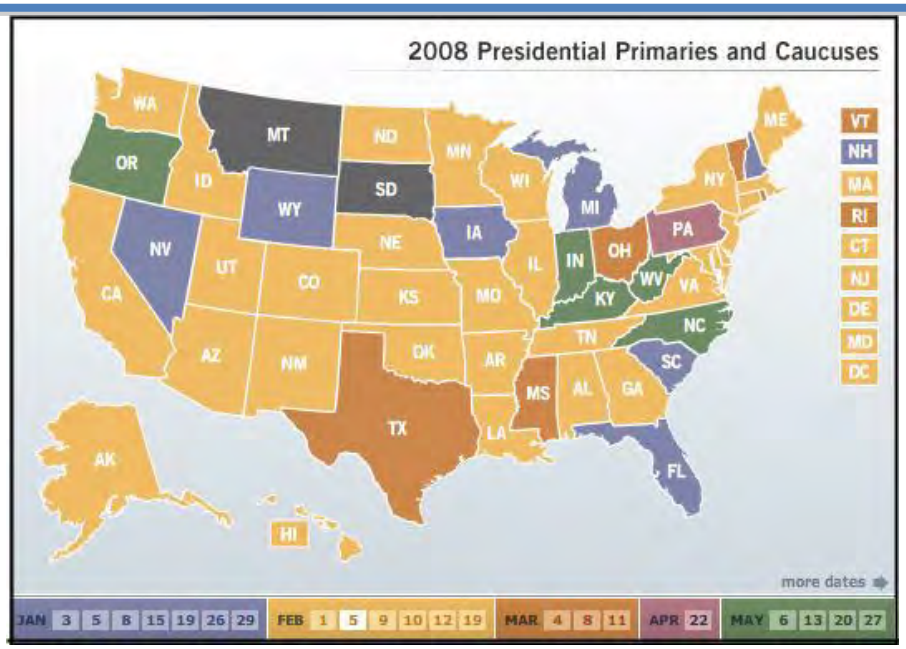
example is that of **incumbent advantage**. Election campaigns in America are very expensive and incumbents, with their existing power and influence over policy, are typically able to raise far greater sums of money than their challengers. Incumbents also often have greater name recognition and receive more media exposure than their challengers, and they enjoy the privilege of sending free mail out to their constituents.

> **Incumbent advantage:** the edge that people already in office over challengers because of greater name recognition and access to campaign finance.

The incumbency advantage is clear in US elections: 86% of incumbent senators and 96% of incumbent congressional representatives who ran in 2002 were successful in their reelection bids. One possible means of reducing the incumbency advantage would be to adopt term limits for members of Congress (as we already have for the President, and for many state Governors and legislatures). On the other hand, some people object that term limits prevent the public from choosing a representative they would prefer and also that it concentrates power in the hands of congressional staff and bureaucracies because they become more experienced than the elected representatives.

A final example of how electoral choice is restricted comes in the form of our **presidential primary** system. Because the media gives a tremendous amount of attention to the winners and losers of the early primaries, the outcome of the primary can become a foregone conclusion long before voters in most states have cast their ballots. This means that relatively small numbers of voters

> **Presidential primary:** an election that determines how many delegates from each state will be sent to the national convention to nominate a party's presidential candidate



Did You Know?

The court decision *Citizens United v. Federal Election Committee* made it possible for outside organizations to accept an unlimited amount of money to independently spend on election candidates. Dubbed "super PACs," these organizations spent a disproportionate amount of money in the early primaries—nearly 13 million in 2012.

decide who will ultimately get to run for office in the general election, and the rest of us are left to choose from amongst their already chosen candidates. Some argue that this is particularly troublesome because the states that hold early primaries are not reflective of the population of the United States as a whole. Iowa and New Hampshire, the two states that traditionally hold the first primaries (or caucus, in Iowa's case) are less ethnically diverse, more rural, and wealthier than the national average.

In recent years, some states have sought to increase their influence on the outcome of the presidential primary process by moving their primaries to earlier dates; this has started a vicious cycle, with states pushing their primaries earlier and earlier to gain or maintain an advantage. The Democratic and Republican parties are trying to discourage these tactics by imposing penalties on states that move their primaries too early (such as reducing the number of delegates the state will be allowed to send to the party's national nominating convention). Some have suggested that the best way to eliminate this problem would be to have a "national primary" in which all states hold their primary elections on the same day. However, opponents argue that a so-called "national primary" would give an even bigger advantage to the best funded candidate and the one with the most name recognition; television advertising would become even more crucial, they say, since it is the most effective way to reach such large numbers of people, and whoever succeeded in raising the money for the advertising would thus have a big advantage.

Discussion Questions

- How does the idea of proportional representation change the make-up of government? Does this seem better or worse than "first past the post"?
- What are some examples of third party issues from current events? What are some political issues that you would like to see the two main parties address that they currently do not?
- Do you think there is enough diversity of opinion within the Democratic and Republican parties?
- Given all the examples in this section, how well do you think our elections reflect the will of the people?

Some Proposals:

The chart below has some arguments for and against the following proposals. Have students research on their own or in groups to fill out their own charts.

	Approaches: Citizenship and Participation	
	Arguments for	**Arguments against**
Increase the range of candidates and parties by moving to a proportional representation system to elect the legislature. Experimenting with proportional representation might begin with state legislatures.	• Proportional representation results in a much closer match between the votes cast and the makeup of the government. • People would feel free to vote for a third party without the risk of "wasting" their vote. • More citizens would have someone to represent their opinions.	• Proportional representation allows too many parties to become part of the government and would lead to a fractured congress that would be unable to form majorities to pass legislation. • It legitimizes extremist factions. • It would be difficult to enact on a widespread basis because of the need for multiple states to pass legislation to adopt it.
Increase the range of candidates and parties by reducing barriers to ballot access for third party candidates	• High barriers to ballot access give an unfair advantage to major party candidates who have many more resources at their disposal than third party candidates.	• If we lowered requirements for ballot access, we could have hundreds of frivolous candidates clogging up ballots, • This would add to voter confusion and create chaos for those who run elections.
Increase competition by making sure that redistricting is done in a non-partisan way.	• It is inherently undemocratic to "fix" an election by manipulating the makeup of a district. • Making redistricting as apolitical as possible will mean that elections are really decided by the will of the people rather than the will of the politicians.	• It is impossible to ensure that districts are drawn in a non-partisan way. Even if an independent body is put in charge, its members have to be appointed by someone (most likely a partisan legislature or governor).

Increase electoral choice by switching to a "national" primary, in which all states vote on the same day.	• Having a national primary would mean that candidates would have to pay attention to voters in every state rather than targeting the states they consider strategically important. • States' influence on candidate selection would become proportionate.	• Having a national primary would make primaries even more expensive and would give a greater advantage to candidates with more financial resources and name recognition. • Campaigns would also become more superficial as candidates would have to try to reach out to voters all across the country all at the same time.
There is no need for change. Our current system provides enough choice.	• Americans have two major parties that act as "umbrellas" for wide ranges of opinions. • There are also often third party candidates and independents, and there are certainly cases where they have been successful (e.g. Jesse Ventura as Governor of Minnesota).	• The current system stacks advantage in favor of just the two major parties and also in favor of incumbents. This means that Americans have only a very limited range of candidates from which to choose. • True democracy requires representation of a broader range of opinions.

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By the People

Serving One's Country

In this view, citizens must do more than just vote and participate in an informed way in making collective choices. Our Republic faces major problems and has a big role to play in the world. If it is to succeed, citizens must be prepared to do their part, serve their country, and if necessary, make sacrifices for the public good. In this view, citizenship is not just about the pursuit of self-interest without harming others or breaking the rules. It is also about being part of collective efforts to solve our collective problems. After all, we all benefit from the successful operation of our democracy. Hence we all need to do our part.

When people hear the phrase "serving your country," they often think of military service. Currently, the American military is an "all-volunteer" force. Proponents argue that this approach is in line with American ideals of liberty. However, the United States has used conscription ("the draft") during several periods in the past (for example, during the two world wars). Males between the ages of 18 and 25 are still required to register for the "**Selective Service System**" so that a draft can be more easily resumed if and when deemed necessary.

> **Selective Service System:** the method through which the U.S. tracks those possibly subject to military

But public service does not have to be military in nature, and there are several federally-sponsored non-military public service programs. One example is AmeriCorps, which funds "volunteers" through a network of non-profit organizations to provide services ranging from public education to building public housing. Another example is the Peace Corps, which sends Americans to help with public service (e.g. health, education) in more than 70 countries around the world. Like the military, these programs are currently run on an all-volunteer basis.

While many people support the status quo of an all-volunteer army, some argue that the US should introduce a mandatory military service period for all US citizens. This would help with military preparedness, they say. Other countries do have military conscription. For example, all Israeli men and women must serve a period in the Israeli Defense Forces.

One point of controversy if mandatory military service were introduced in the US would be the question of whether it would include women as well as men. As noted above, only men are currently required to register for the Selective Service System, and this has raised complaints of discrimination by women's groups. Additionally, some argue that an all-volunteer merely forces those who have no other options or job opportunities—the most unfortunate—into military service.

Some people argue that a period of national service should be mandatory in the US, but say that citizens should have options other than the military. For example, the service obligation could be fulfilled by time with a non-profit organization working for the public good (as is now done through AmeriCorps). Germany has a system like this, in which all males must serve for 9 months either in the military or in a civil protection (e.g. disaster preparedness) or other public service organization.

Discussion Questions

- Do you think that military service is comparable to service in the Peace Corps?
- If there were mandatory military or volunteer service, how would it affect your life? Do you like the idea?
- What do you think about the fact that only men have to register for the Selective Service System?
- Which do you think is more important for democracy—voting or volunteer service?

Some Proposals:

The chart below has some arguments for and against the following proposals. Have students research on their own or in groups to fill out their own charts.

	Approaches: Serving One's Country	
	Arguments for	**Arguments against**
Keep our current system of an all-volunteer military and public service opportunities on a voluntary basis	• The current system of voluntary military service provides plenty of opportunities for those who wish to devote a period of time serving their country. • It also avoids the problems that arise from forcing people to serve against their will (just recall the turmoil caused by the draft during the Vietnam War).	• The current system fails to instill a sense of civic duty and pride in our citizens. • Having an all-volunteer military does not reduce the need for military personnel; it merely shifts the burden of military service on those with fewer resources and opportunities available to them (i.e. the poor).
Keep our current system, but expand volunteer public service programs such as AmeriCorps and Peace Corps	• These volunteer organizations do valuable and important work while at the same time promoting the principle of public service. • These kinds of activities are best performed by people who are motivated; people who are forced into public service might not have the same level of commitment	• Public service programs are expensive and expanding them would be costly. • Expanding volunteer programs falls far short of implementing any serious effort for public service as only a few will take advantage of such opportunities.
Require a period of public service by all citizens, either in the military or in non-military programs working for the public good	• Requiring a period of public service would help citizens understand and respect the responsibilities of belonging to a society as well as enjoying its benefits. • Those who are opposed to military service will still have options that contribute to collective problem solving.	• Mandatory public service runs contrary to the idea of personal liberty. • Conscripts are likely to be less committed than volunteers, both in military and non-military contexts.

Require a period of military service by all citizens	• Requiring universal military service will improve military preparedness. • It will help to more evenly distribute the burden of military service. Under our current all-volunteer system, poor people and minorities are over-represented in the military because they lack other opportunities; thus disadvantaged citizens bear a disproportionate share of the burden.	• Requiring military service would weaken the military by bringing in a flood of people who do not want to be there and who may not be committed or well-suited for military service. • It could take a toll on the economy as it would be a big drain on labor resources.

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By the People

Becoming Informed

Citizens are not just required to participate or to exercise choice, they must also do so in an informed way. How can they be responsible citizens if they do not know the issues, if they do not know the differences between the candidates? Is it irresponsible to vote based on personality without any consideration for what candidates will do? This point of view sees making an informed choice about issues, policy positions and their consequences, as a necessary part of citizenship. Citizens have an obligation to become informed before they vote or participate. Only then will democracy produce a meaningful expression of the "will of the people."

Americans currently score pretty low on levels of political knowledge, as demonstrated by many studies. In a 2007 study by the Pew Research Center, for example, only 49% could correctly identify Nancy Pelosi as the Speaker of the House of Representatives, and only 37% knew that the current Chief Justice of the Supreme Court is a conservative. 45% were unable to correctly identify the approximate number of American military personnel killed so far in Iraq.

The media are often blamed for the lack of political knowledge among American citizens. American television news programs – especially local TV news, which is watched by more people than watch the network newscasts – tend to focus on stories that are dramatic or sensational in order to appeal to a wider audience. Political stories are considered boring and garner little media attention. During major political campaigns, when it is harder to ignore politics completely, the media tend to focus on superficial topics such as the horse race (who's ahead, who's behind) and candidates' personal lives (will a candidate's husband or wife hurt or help their chances?). There is very little in-depth coverage of issues or candidates' positions on them. Other countries place stricter public interest demands on television networks that use the public airwaves, and consequently have higher levels of political coverage. Some argue that one way to increase levels of political information among citizens is to increase the public interest obligations of broadcasters. For example, many countries require their broadcasters to devote a minimum percentage of their airtime to public affairs programming, or to provide coverage of minority as well as majority viewpoints on political issues.

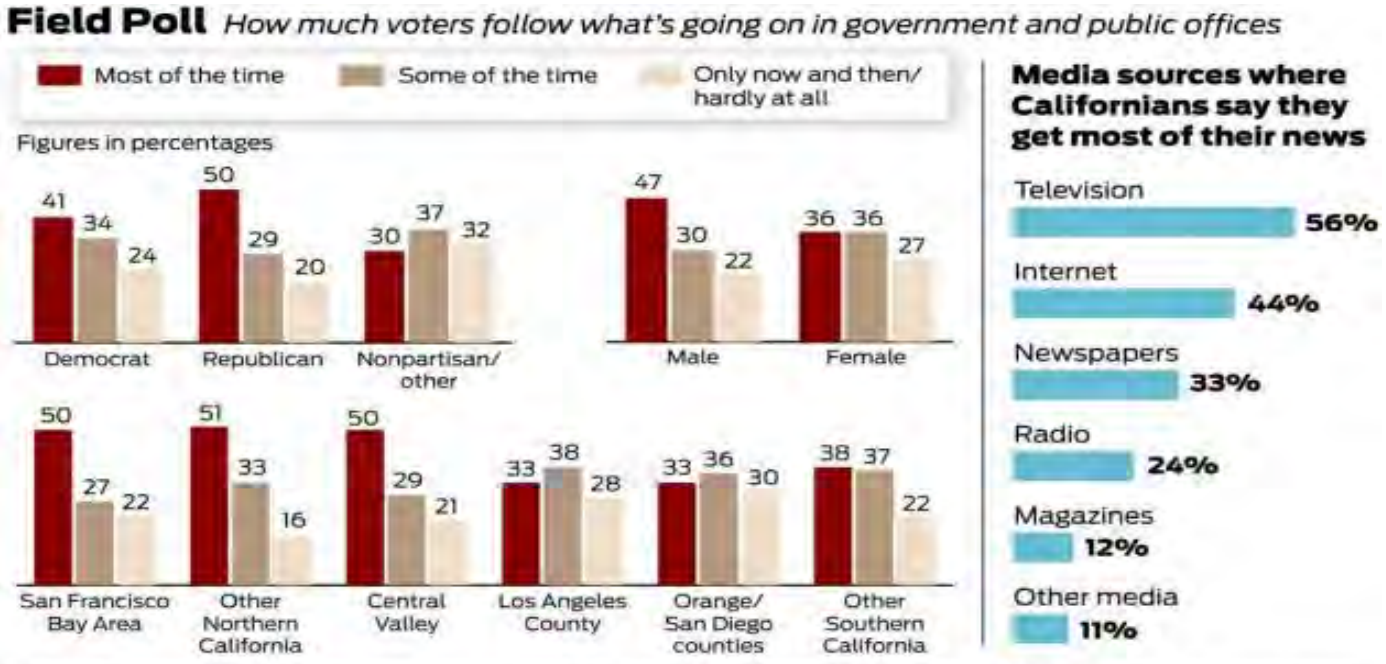
Because American campaigns are conducted almost entirely through the media, candidates are also very dependent on TV commercials to

attract voters. Some argue that a 30-second TV spot is hardly an ideal format for candidates to share information about their policy positions. Instead, candidates aim to come up with ads that either attract voters through basic appeals (creating an image as a "family man," for example) or that try to turn off an opponent's supporters through the use of negative tactics ("my opponent is untrustworthy"). While these ads may provide some information, they fail to address the policy issues at hand. In many other democracies, candidates are given blocks of free airtime on television. This allows for presentations that focus on the issues than can be crammed into a 30-second slot, proponents say. It allows candidates to cover serious topics that are regarded as too boring by the news media.

Other people argue that the reason for low levels of political knowledge might not be the supply of information, but rather with unequal opportunities for citizens to take advantage of it. These people note that there are differences between citizens with high levels of knowledge and those with low levels of knowledge. For example, wealthier people tend to be considerably more informed than poor people. One contributing factor to this might be that poor people are less likely to have internet access; 76% of people with an income over $75,000 have a broadband connection at home,

while only 30% of those with an income under $30,000 have one. There is now a huge quantity of political information available on the web (candidate websites listing issue positions and providing text of speeches, for example), but this is of no use to people who do not have internet access. One way to reduce the inequality of information between wealthy and poor people would be to provide all citizens with easy access to the internet.

Reformers have suggested that we need to find new ways of engaging all citizens and helping them learn about politics. One proposal is to



provide public funding for **non-partisan** voter information groups who aim to help voters become informed. There are, for example, organizations that gather information about candidates' issue positions, voting records, campaign financing, interest group support, and/or public statements. This information is in many cases made available on the web. Some organizations even offer a toll free phone number that citizens can call to get information about the candidates in their area. Providing public funding for these and other civic education initiatives would allow such efforts to become more widespread and to come up with novel ways to share information with citizens.

Non-Partisan: not associated with any political party

There are others who argue that Americans' low levels of political knowledge don't matter and that voters can still make good decisions without having to learn in-depth about the candidates and their issue positions. These people argue that citizens can successfully approximate their "correct" voting decisions (i.e., the decisions they would take if they were fully informed) by using shortcuts; voters can rely on a candidate's party identification and on endorsements by public officials they trust, for example. In this view, citizens have plenty of information to make the correct voting decisions without ever needing to know who the Speaker of the House is.

Discussion Questions

- What sources do you use to get news about current events? How reliable do you think they are?
- What do you think about political advertisements? Do you think they help people make informed political decisions?
- Do you think it is necessary to know a politician's view on every issue in order to make an informed vote, or could you decide based on other factors? What would they be?

Some Proposals:

The chart below has some arguments for and against the following proposals. Have students research on their own or in groups to fill out their own charts.

	Approaches: Becoming Informed	
	Arguments for	**Arguments against**
Increase opportunities for citizens to become informed by increasing public interest requirements of broadcasters.	• As television is a main source of political information for most citizens, increasing the amount of political coverage on television would thus be likely to increase political knowledge. • Networks get to use the public airwaves and it is reasonable to expect them to contribute to the public good.	• Even if television networks increased their public interest programming, that would not guarantee that citizens would watch it. • There is also no way to be sure that more coverage would be better coverage; more sensationalist coverage would not make citizens more informed on the issues.
Increase the opportunities for citizens to become informed by providing free air time to candidates	• Providing free air time would enhance candidates' abilities to address substantive issues, since candidates cannot afford to buy big blocks and the 30-second spots that they are able to buy do not give enough time for them to address substantive topics. • Free air time would erase some of the advantage enjoyed by candidates with more money.	• There is no guarantee that candidates would use free airtime to cover more substantive topics; they could still choose to make superficial appeals or just to attack their opponents. • There is also no guarantee that voters would watch longer political campaign ads/programs even if they were on TV.
Decrease the gap in political knowledge between wealthy and poor people by using public funding to make sure that all citizens have access to the internet.	• The internet provides an unparalleled opportunity for citizens to inform themselves about political issues from a wide variety of sources.	• We cannot be sure that people use their publicly funded internet access to learn about politics.

	• More and more candidates and elected officials make information and services available online.	• Even if they do, the internet is full of unreliable sources and can make citizens more misinformed than informed.
Provide public funding for non-partisan civic education groups that gather relevant political information and make it available to the citizens who need it.	• Average citizens do not have time to dig for all the information they might need to make an informed choice between candidates. • Dedicated civic education groups can sift through multiple sources to come up with a comprehensive and balanced guide for citizens. • Citizens are much more likely to make use of this information if they can find it all in one place.	• It would be difficult to guarantee that these groups were really non-partisan. • There is no guarantee that citizens would take advantage of it and public funding of such efforts would be a waste of taxpayer dollars.
It is not necessary to increase opportunities for citizens to become informed.	• Citizens learn as much about politics as they feel they need to know to make the right decisions for them. • There are many shortcuts that citizens can take to make effective decisions without studying the issues in-depth.	• There are numerous examples of cases in which people seem to have voted against their own interests or against positions that they seem to hold. • Lack of information leaves voters vulnerable to manipulation by candidates who know how to use advertising techniques.

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By the People

Citizenship in 21st Century America

The United States is a **representative democracy**, in which government officials are selected by the people they represent. However, many have questioned whether democracy in the U.S. is working as it should. Almost half of those eligible to vote do not do so in presidential elections (even fewer participate in lower-level elections), and studies have found that many Americans do not have even basic knowledge about their elected representatives or the workings of our government.

> **Representative Democracy:** a form of government where citizens vote for officials to represent their desires indirectly in the government

Today's citizens are faced with a very different world than that of the Founding Fathers who established our democracy. Our country is much larger and communication is different than it was when the United States began. Instead of a small, mostly rural society of some three million people, we now have close to 300 million, mostly urban and suburban, residents. Instead of sending letters from Virginia to Boston that had to go by boat to England and then back again to America, we are all instantaneously connected electronically (through the internet and cell phones) and physically (by airplanes). Instead of just 30,000 people in a Congressional District, we are now approaching 800,000. In the modern United States, election campaigns are conducted through mass media rather than by grassroots and are controlled by highly skilled political strategists. Although the internet and 24-hour news organizations may make political information more readily available, there is frequently an emphasis on who is ahead in the polls at the moment or on candidates' personal lives rather than on policy matters.

Suppose we have a society of "spectator citizens," who do little and are not involved in their democracy. Does it matter if people do not exercise any real choices, do not know much about politics and policy and do little in the way of public service or patriotism? Why? What must individual citizens do to make our democracy work? And what, if anything, can they reasonably be expected to do given the other pressures their daily lives? These are issues for our discussion.

We will focus on four paths of citizen involvement in government: participating in politics, exercising choice, serving one's country and becoming informed. In each case, there are different views ideas about the kinds of institutions and policies we might need—provided that each activity is something we think citizens in a democracy should do. In each case, we can ask: are these requirements of citizenship? Or might we decide that they are not really matters of public concern?

Citizenship and Participation

Some people think that the first duty of a citizen is to participate in politics. In representative democracies, election time is the key moment for citizens to express their preferences and influence how their country is governed. If a citizen does not vote, he or she gives up that influence. When failure to vote is a result of citizen disengagement or some deliberate effort to decrease the number of voters, an election with low turnout is unlikely to produce an accurate representation of the will of the people. And since those who do not vote tend to be demographically different from those that do (e.g. poor people are less likely to vote than wealthier people, young people less likely than old people), groups that do not vote may have less influence on policy outcomes.

America has one of the lowest rates of voter participation of any democracy in the world. Even in a presidential election, only about half the eligible voters turn out. In the presidential primary process and in state and local elections, the participation rate is much lower: in the single digits in some cases.

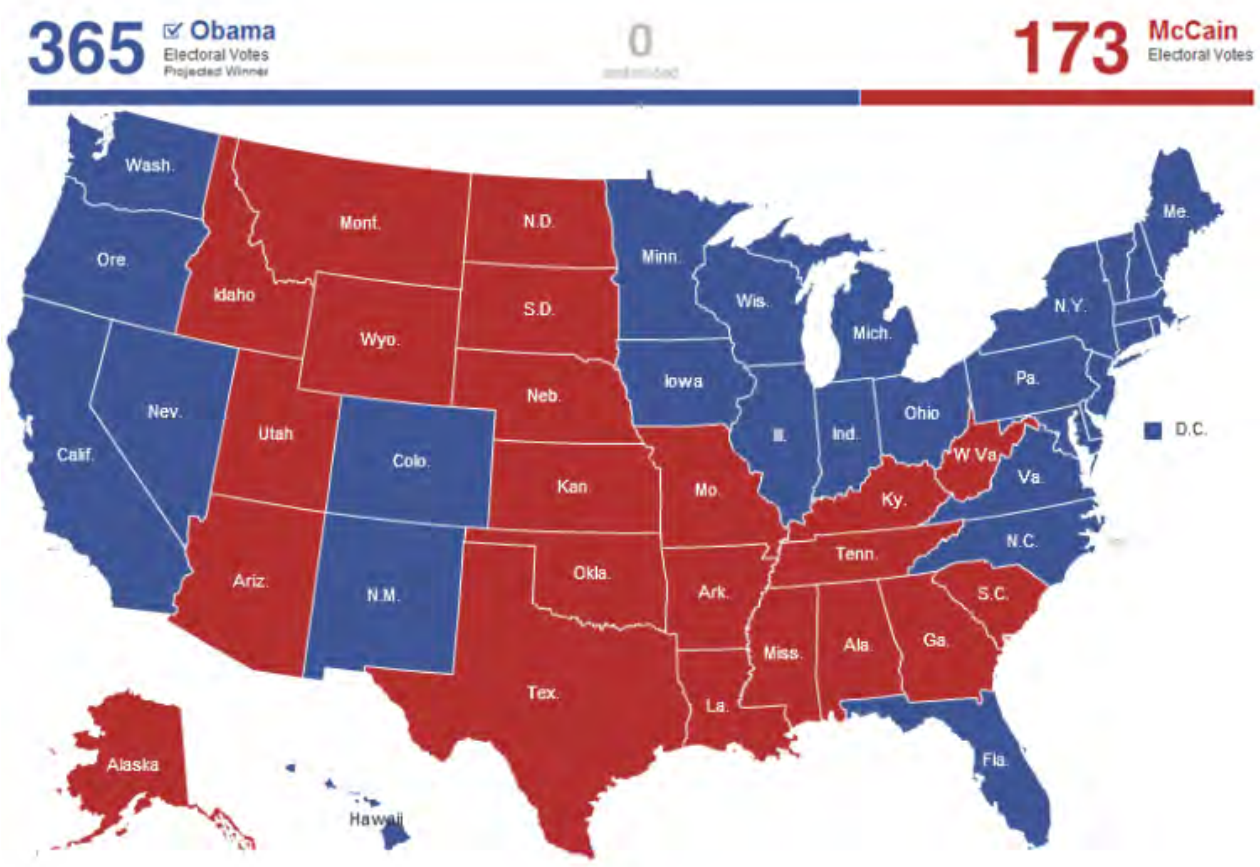
What factors contribute to our low voter turnout? Some argue that our election laws themselves make it more difficult for people to participate. For example, Election Day is usually on a weekday (the first Tuesday in November for presidential and congressional elections), and it may be difficult for people to get away from work to vote. To make voting easier, some states allow citizens to cast "early votes" in the run up to Election Day and/or to cast "absentee" votes by mail. However, other states do not have such measures in place, and critics argue that this is unfair because it makes it more difficult for some citizens to vote than others. Some suggest that Election Day should be a national holiday so that citizens in all states would have an equal and increased opportunity to vote.

In many states, furthermore, it is necessary to register weeks before Election Day in order to be eligible to vote. Critics point out that, since citizen awareness of campaigns and elections reaches its peak just shortly before Election Day, many citizens might not even be aware of an upcoming election at the time of the voter registration deadline. People who forget or don't have time or do not realize they need to register by the deadline then cannot have their votes counted on Election Day. Several states in the U.S. allow voters to register on Election Day itself, and these states tend to have significantly higher turnout than states that do not allow Election Day registration.

A more direct reduction in participation is brought about by laws in many states that bar convicted criminals from the political process. 48 states do not allow citizens in prison for a felony to vote, and it is illegal in the majority of states for felons who are on parole or probation to vote. Even after they have completed their sentences, convicted felons in some states are not allowed to vote. About five million Americans are unable to participate in elections for these reasons.

> **Swing State:** A state that could potentially be won by either a Democrat or a Republican

Some argue that our political institutions themselves discourage voter participation. The system means that only so-called **"swing**



The most recent Electoral College results

states" are in play in presidential elections. It is assumed, for example, that California's **Electoral College** votes will always go to the Democratic candidate. Thus both Democrats and Republicans in California have less incentive to vote; some Democrats may not bother voting because they think they are going to win anyway, and some Republicans may not bother because they assume they are going to lose. Candidates tend to give little attention to states that have safe majorities of one party or the other and instead focus their campaign resources on the "swing states" where they might sway enough voters to move that state into their own Electoral College camp. This means that perhaps 22 states out of 50 are likely to experience serious campaigning and television advertising, while voters in other states are left as second-hand observers to campaigns in which the ads are not even shown in their states. Voters in non-swing states therefore experience lower voter turnout. Without the Electoral College, Republicans in California and Democrats in the Deep South would be part of the presidential campaign in the general election.

Electoral College: the system by which US presidents are elected; if a candidate wins the majority of votes in a state, he or she would win ALL of that state's electoral college votes; because of the Electoral College, it is possible to get a minority of the popular vote and still win the election

Other countries have found more direct ways to ensure high voter turnout, such as making voting required by law. In Australia, citizens who do not vote are subject to paying a fine and in Belgium, repeated failure to vote can lead to having your right to vote permanently canceled. These required voting laws do result in higher turnout: Australia and Belgium average over 90%. 32 countries currently have some kind of compulsory voting law.

On the other hand, there are those who say that low levels of voter participation are not worrisome. We have relatively respectable levels of participation from those who are registered to vote, they argue. It is just that, unlike most countries, we put the burden of registration entirely on the individual (in many other countries, voters are automatically registered by the government). If citizens do not even bother to register, then why should we be concerned about their votes? If people can't take the time to register, how informed or involved could they be in the campaign? According to this view, we should not be concerned about the preferences of those who cannot make even a minimal effort to get to the polls once every year or two.

And of course, it must be recognized that voting is not the only form of political participation. Showing up at rallies, writing letters to public officials such as members of congress, contributing to campaigns, or even just discussing one's political views might all be considered forms of political participation. In this regard, the spread of the web has dramatically increased opportunities for political participation (consider the massive number of political blogs, for example, or the success of online political organizing tools).

Discussion Questions

- What are the benefits of a representative democracy as compared to a direct democracy?
- Is it important to be informed about the government or election campaigns? Why or why not?
- How do election laws impact the number of people and the kinds of people that turn out to vote?
- Does the Electoral College make elections more or less fair?
- If you were 18, would you vote? On what information would you base your decision?

Some Proposals:

Fill in the chart below with arguments for and against the following proposals

	Approaches: Citizenship and Participation	
	Arguments for	**Arguments against**
Increase voter participation by making Election Day a national holiday.		
Increase voter participation by allowing Election Day registration		
Increase voter participation by allowing felons to vote after they have served their sentences		
Increase voter participation by abolishing the Electoral College and substituting direct election of the president by popular vote		
Increase voter participation by switching to "compulsory voting," with fines or other penalties for those that don't comply		
It is not necessary to increase voter turnout; low turnout is not a problem for a democracy		

This background was prepared for *By the People* by the Center for Deliberative Democracy. BTP is partnering with the Colonial Williamsburg Foundation on the *Dialogue in Democracy* project. Ongoing BTP project funding partners include the W.K. Kellogg Foundation and the Rockefeller Brothers Fund.

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By the People

Exercising Choice

From this perspective, the central duty of citizens is not just to show up, it is also to exercise choice. The essence of democracy is that the public makes collective choices and the duty of each citizen is to take part in those decisions. But choices can only be made from among the available options, and it is hard for individual citizens to exercise choice if elections are not competitive. If the results are already decided beforehand, why should we expect voters to spend a lot of time and trouble registering their preferences? This view therefore emphasizes not just the role of citizens, but the context within which they must play that role. We need to have elections where there is enough competition for citizens to realize that their participation can make a difference. When parties compete, voters win. With competition, the voters can hold elected officials accountable; if voters have no real alternatives to the status quo, they have no way to register their disapproval of incompetence, corruption, or poor policy choices (or reward the opposite).

The United States essentially has a two-party system. Although this is not required by the Constitution, it is encouraged by our "**first-past-the-post**" voting system, by our non-parliamentary government, and by ballot access laws that set high barriers to entry into the electoral process (e.g. requiring the collection of large numbers of signatures to be eligible to run).

> **First-past-the-post:** the candidate who gets the most votes is elected, even if they don't reach a 50% majority

Some people argue that there is little difference between the Democratic and Republican parties, and that we need to encourage the inclusion of candidates representing a broader range of policy positions. In this view, both Democratic and

Republican candidates rush to the middle in order to appeal to the greatest number of voters, thus leaving no real choices for people whose beliefs are further to the left or to the right on the political spectrum.

One way to increase the range of candidates would be to switch to a "proportional

representation" voting system, some version of which is used in most major democracies.

Proportional representation: the number of seats won by a party matches the number of votes that it received.

Proportional representation seeks to provide a close match between the percentage of votes that a party receives in an election and the number of seats they are given in the governing body. To illustrate: imagine an area called Citizenville that has a total of five congressional districts; 40% of voters in Citizenville are Democrats, 40% are Republicans, and 20% are supporters of the Alternative Party. Under our current first-past-the-post voting system, each of Citizenville's five districts has a separate election to choose its own representative. In Citizenville District 1, 41% of the vote in this election goes to the Republican, 39% to the Democrat, and 20% to the Alternative; the Republican is elected and 59% of District 1's voters have no one in Congress that represents their views. Similar outcomes occur in Citizenville Districts 2, 3, 4, and 5, so Citizenville elects five Republicans.

Under proportional representation, Citizenville would most likely elect two Democrats, two Republicans, and one Alternative. Citizenville's citizens would have three viable candidates to choose from instead of just two, and every citizen would have at least one official in Congress to represent his or her views. Proportional representation is currently in use in a small number of local electoral contexts (e.g. for school boards or city councils) around the U.S., but proponents would like to see it used in state and even federal elections.

Others have suggested that an easier way to increase electoral choice for American voters would be to reduce the barriers to ballot access that are currently in place and that often put third party candidates at a major disadvantage. In many states, the candidates of the major parties are automatically given a place on the ballot, while third party candidates have to go through a time- and resource-consuming process of signature collection to qualify. Critics argue that these measures solidify the powerful positions of the two major parties and make it difficult for third parties to break into the process.

On the other hand, some people feel that the two-party system provides plenty of choice for American voters. They point out that, unlike in many other democracies, American elected officials typically have wide choice to vote as they (or their constituents) please regardless of their party affiliation. For example, while the Democratic Party as a whole may have a reputation of being pro-choice, there are certainly Democratic representatives that are against abortion; likewise, while the Republican Party overall may be against gun control, some elected Republicans vote in favor of it. While elected officials in many other countries may be expelled from their party if they vote against the party line, that is not the case in the United States. Thus, some argue, there is a broad range of opinion represented in Congress even though there are only two major parties.

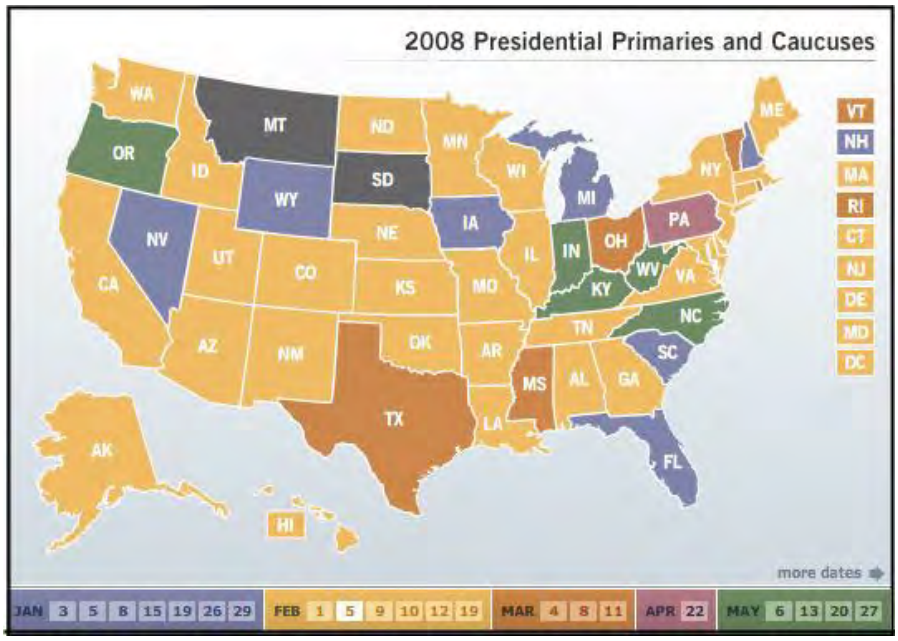
But even if our current two-party system is considered adequate, there are many other ways in which the competitiveness of elections is systematically reduced. One example is that of **incumbent advantage**. Election campaigns in America are very expensive and incumbents, with their existing power and influence over policy, are typically able to raise far greater sums of money than their challengers. Incumbents also often have greater name recognition and receive more media exposure than their challengers, and they enjoy the privilege of sending free mail out to their constituents.

Incumbent advantage: the edge that people already in office over challengers because of greater name recognition and access to campaign finance.

The incumbency advantage is clear in US elections: 86% of incumbent senators and 96% of incumbent congressional representatives who ran in 2002 were successful in their reelection bids. One possible means of reducing the incumbency advantage would be to adopt term limits for members of Congress (as we already have for the President, and for many state Governors and legislatures). On the other hand, some people object that term limits prevent the public from choosing a representative they would prefer and also that it concentrates power in the hands of congressional staff and bureaucracies because they become more experienced than the elected representatives.

A final example of how electoral choice is restricted comes in the form of our **presidential primary** system. Because the media gives a tremendous amount of attention to the winners and losers of the early primaries, the outcome of the primary can become a foregone conclusion long before voters in most states have cast their ballots. This means that relatively small numbers of voters decide who

Presidential primary: an election that determines how many delegates from each state will be sent to the national convention to nominate a party's presidential candidate



Did You Know?

The court decision *Citizens United v. Federal Election Committee* made it possible for outside organizations to accept an unlimited amount of money to independently spend on election candidates. Dubbed "super PACs," these organizations spent a disproportionate amount of money in the early primaries—nearly 13 million in 2012.

will ultimately get to run for office in the general election, and the rest of us are left to choose from amongst their already chosen candidates. Some argue that this is particularly troublesome because the states that hold early primaries are not reflective of the population of the United States as a whole. Iowa and New Hampshire, the two states that traditionally hold the first primaries (or caucus, in Iowa's case) are less ethnically diverse, more rural, and wealthier than the national average.

In recent years, some states have sought to increase their influence on the outcome of the presidential primary process by moving their primaries to earlier dates; this has started a vicious cycle, with states pushing their primaries earlier and earlier to gain or maintain an advantage. The Democratic and Republican parties are trying to discourage these tactics by imposing penalties on states that move their primaries too early (such as reducing the number of delegates the state will be allowed to send to the party's national nominating convention). Some have suggested that the best way to eliminate this problem would be to have a "national primary" in which all states hold their primary elections on the same day. However, opponents argue that a so-called "national primary" would give an even bigger advantage to the best funded candidate and the one with the most name recognition; television advertising would become even more crucial, they say, since it is the most effective way to reach such large numbers of people, and whoever succeeded in raising the money for the advertising would thus have a big advantage.

Discussion Questions

- How does the idea of proportional representation change the make-up of government? Does this seem better or worse than "first past the post"?
- What are some examples of third party issues from current events? What are some political issues that you would like to see the two main parties address that they currently do not?
- Do you think there is enough diversity of opinion within the Democratic and Republican parties?
- Given all the examples in this section, how well do you think our elections reflect the will of the people?

Some Proposals:

Fill out the chart below with arguments for and against the following proposals

	Approaches: Citizenship and Participation	
	Arguments for	**Arguments against**
Increase the range of candidates and parties by moving to a proportional representation system to elect the legislature, perhaps beginning with state legislatures.		
Increase the range of candidates and parties by reducing barriers to ballot access for third party candidates		
Increase competition by reducing incumbency advantage through the adoption of term limits for members of Congress		
Increase competition by making sure that redistricting is done in a non-partisan way.		
Increase electoral choice by switching to a “national” primary, in which all states vote on the same day.		
There is no need for change. Our current system provides enough choice.		

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By the People

Serving One's Country

In this view, citizens must do more than just vote and participate in an informed way in making collective choices. Our Republic faces major problems and has a big role to play in the world. If it is to succeed, citizens must be prepared to do their part, serve their country, and if necessary, make sacrifices for the public good. In this view, citizenship is not just about the pursuit of self-interest without harming others or breaking the rules. It is also about being part of collective efforts to solve our collective problems. After all, we all benefit from the successful operation of our democracy. Hence we all need to do our part.

When people hear the phrase "serving your country," they often think of military service. Currently, the American military is an "all-volunteer" force. Proponents argue that this approach is in line with American ideals of liberty. However, the United States has used conscription ("the draft") during several periods in the past (for example, during the two world wars). Males between the ages of 18 and 25 are still required to register for the "Selective Service System" so that a draft can be more easily resumed if and when deemed necessary.

Selective Service System: the method through which the U.S. tracks those possibly subject to military

But public service does not have to be military in nature, and there are several federally-sponsored non-military public service programs. One example is AmeriCorps, which funds "volunteers" through a network of non-profit organizations to provide services ranging from public education to building public housing. Another example is the Peace Corps, which sends Americans to help with public service (e.g. health, education) in more than 70 countries around the world. Like the military, these programs are currently run on an all-volunteer basis.

While many people support the status quo of an all-volunteer army, some argue that the US should introduce a mandatory military service period for all US citizens. This would help with military preparedness, they say. Other countries do have military conscription. For example, all Israeli men and women must serve a period in the Israeli Defense Forces.

One point of controversy if mandatory military service were introduced in the US would be the question of whether it would include women as well as men. As noted above, only men are currently required to register for the Selective Service System, and this has raised complaints of discrimination by women's groups. Additionally, some argue that an all-volunteer merely forces those who have no other options or job opportunities—the most unfortunate—into military service.

Some people argue that a period of national service should be mandatory in the US, but say that citizens should have options other than the military. For example, the service obligation could be fulfilled by time with a non-profit organization working for the public good (as is now done through AmeriCorps). Germany has a system like this, in which all males must serve for 9 months either in the military or in a civil protection (e.g. disaster preparedness) or other public service organization.

Discussion Questions

- Do you think that military service is comparable to service in the Peace Corps?
- If there were mandatory military or volunteer service, how would it affect your life? Do you like the idea?
- What do you think about the fact that only men have to register for the Selective Service System?
- Which do you think is more important for democracy—voting or volunteer service?

Some Proposals:

Fill in the chart below with arguments for and against the following proposals

	Approaches: Serving One's Country	
	Arguments for	**Arguments against**
Keep our current system of an all-volunteer military and public service opportunities on a voluntary basis		
Keep our current system, but expand volunteer public service programs such as AmeriCorps and Peace Corps		
Require a period of public service by all citizens, either in the military or in non-military programs working for the public good		
Require a period of military service by all citizens		

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By the People

Becoming Informed

Citizens are not just required to participate or to exercise choice, they must also do so in an informed way. How can they be responsible citizens if they do not know the issues, if they do not know the differences between the candidates? Is it irresponsible to vote based on personality without any consideration for what candidates will do? This point of view sees making an informed choice about issues, policy positions and their consequences, as a necessary part of citizenship. Citizens have an obligation to become informed before they vote or participate. Only then will democracy produce a meaningful expression of the "will of the people."

Americans currently score pretty low on levels of political knowledge, as demonstrated by many studies. In a 2007 study by the Pew Research Center, for example, only 49% could correctly identify Nancy Pelosi as the Speaker of the House of Representatives, and only 37% knew that the current Chief Justice of the Supreme Court is a conservative. 45% were unable to correctly identify the approximate number of American military personnel killed so far in Iraq.

The media are often blamed for the lack of political knowledge among American citizens. American television news programs – especially local TV news, which is watched by more people than watch the network newscasts – tend to focus on stories that are dramatic or sensational in order to appeal to a wider audience. Political stories are considered boring and garner little media attention. During major political campaigns, when it is harder to ignore politics completely, the media tend to focus on superficial topics such as the horse race (who's ahead, who's behind) and candidates' personal lives (will a candidate's husband or wife hurt or help their chances?). There is very little in-depth coverage of issues or candidates' positions on them. Other countries place stricter public interest demands on television networks that use the public airwaves, and consequently have higher levels of political coverage. Some argue that one way to increase levels of political information among citizens is to increase the public interest obligations of broadcasters. For example, many countries require their broadcasters to devote a minimum percentage of their airtime to public affairs programming, or to provide coverage of minority as well as majority viewpoints on political issues.

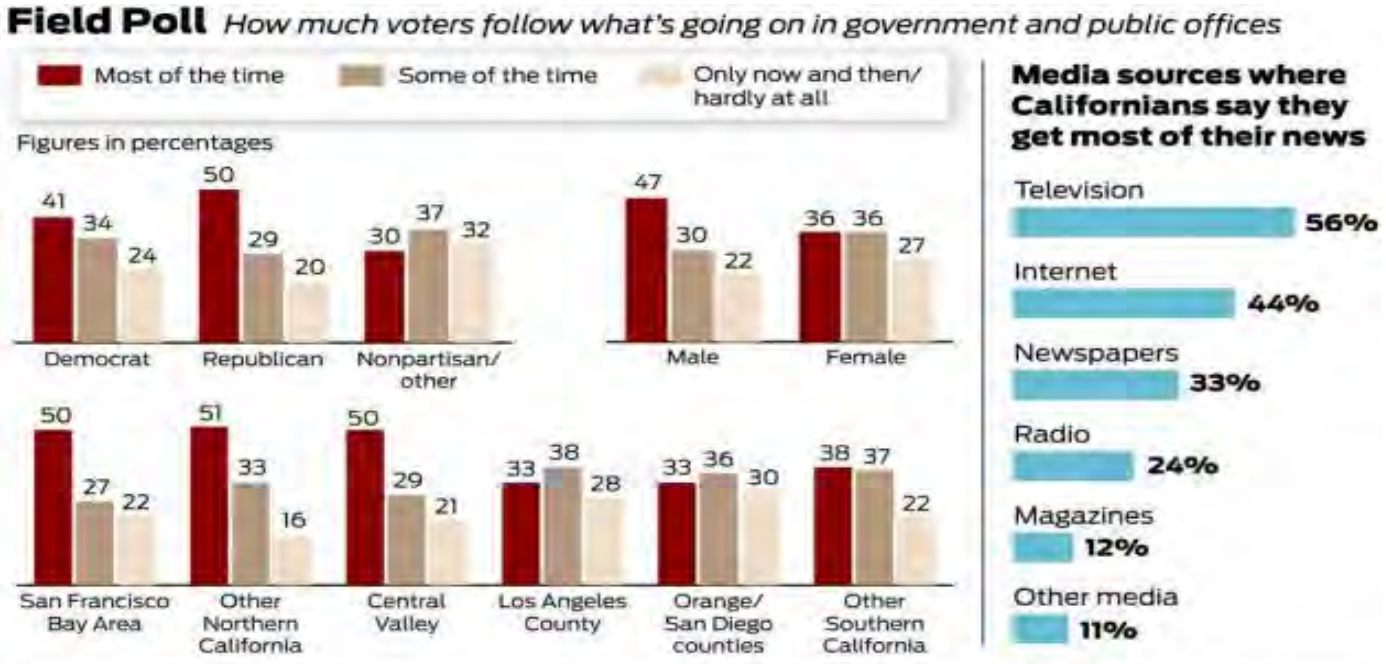
Because American campaigns are conducted almost entirely through the media, candidates are also very dependent on TV commercials to

attract voters. Some argue that a 30-second TV spot is hardly an ideal format for candidates to share information about their policy positions. Instead, candidates aim to come up with ads that either attract voters through basic appeals (creating an image as a "family man," for example) or that try to turn off an opponent's supporters through the use of negative tactics ("my opponent is untrustworthy"). While these ads may provide some information, they fail to address the policy issues at hand. In many other democracies, candidates are given blocks of free airtime on television. This allows for presentations that focus on the issues than can be crammed into a 30-second slot, proponents say. It allows candidates to cover serious topics that are regarded as too boring by the news media.

Other people argue that the reason for low levels of political knowledge might not be the supply of information, but rather with unequal opportunities for citizens to take advantage of it. These people note that there are differences between citizens with high levels of knowledge and those with low levels of knowledge. For example, wealthier people tend to be considerably more informed than poor people. One contributing factor to this might be that poor people are less likely to have internet access; 76% of people with an income over $75,000 have a broadband connection at home,

while only 30% of those with an income under $30,000 have one. There is now a huge quantity of political information available on the web (candidate websites listing issue positions and providing text of speeches, for example), but this is of no use to people who do not have internet access. One way to reduce the inequality of information between wealthy and poor people would be to provide all citizens with easy access to the internet.

Reformers have suggested that we need to find new ways of engaging all citizens and helping them learn about politics. One proposal is to



provide public funding for **non-partisan** voter information groups who aim to help voters become informed. There are, for example, organizations that gather information about candidates' issue positions, voting records, campaign financing, interest group support, and/or public statements. This information is in many cases made available on the web. Some organizations even offer a toll free phone number that citizens can call to get information about the candidates in their area. Providing public funding for these and other civic education initiatives would allow such efforts to become more widespread and to come up with novel ways to share information with citizens.

Non-Partisan: not associated with any political party

There are others who argue that Americans' low levels of political knowledge don't matter and that voters can still make good decisions without having to learn in-depth about the candidates and their issue positions. These people argue that citizens can successfully approximate their "correct" voting decisions (i.e., the decisions they would take if they were fully informed) by using shortcuts; voters can rely on a candidate's party identification and on endorsements by public officials they trust, for example. In this view, citizens have plenty of information to make the correct voting decisions without ever needing to know who the Speaker of the House is.

Discussion Questions

- What sources do you use to get news about current events? How reliable do you think they are?
- What do you think about political advertisements? Do you think they help people make informed political decisions?
- Do you think it is necessary to know a politician's view on every issue in order to make an informed vote, or could you decide based on other factors? What would they be?

Some Proposals:

Fill in the chart below with arguments for and against the following proposals

	Approaches: Becoming Informed	
	Arguments for	**Arguments against**
Increase opportunities for citizens to become informed by increasing public interest requirements of broadcasters.		
Increase the opportunities for citizens to become informed by providing free air time to candidates		
Decrease the gap in political knowledge between wealthy and poor people by using public funding to make sure that all citizens have access to the internet.		
Provide public funding for non-partisan civic education groups that gather relevant political information and make it available to the citizens who need it.		
It is not necessary to increase opportunities for citizens to become informed.		

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Deliberative Polling—Pre-survey

1. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think each of the following is to being a good citizen?

	Completely Unimportant					Neither important nor unimportant					Extremely important		No opinion
a. Voting in elections	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
b. Discussing politics with others	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. Being informed about politics and political issues	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. Serving one's country through military or public service	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

2. And how strongly would you favor or oppose each of the following?

	Favor strongly	Favor somewhat	Neither favor nor oppose	Oppose somewhat	Oppose strongly		No Opinion
a. Making Election Day a national holiday	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Allowing Election Day registration	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Allowing felons to vote after they have served their sentences	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Replacing the Electoral College with direct election of the president	1	2	3	4	5		99

3. And on a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely ineffective, 10 is completely effective, and 5 is exactly in-between, how effective do you think each of the following measures would be in increasing voter participation?

	Completely ineffective					Neither effective nor ineffective					Completely effective		No opinion
a. Making Election Day a national holiday	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
b. Allowing Election Day registration	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. Allowing felons to vote after they have served their sentences	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
d. Replacing the Electoral College with direct election of the president	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
e. Fining people who don't vote	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

Deliberative Polling—Pre-survey

4. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think it is to increase political participation in the US?

Completely Unimportant					Neither important nor unimportant					Extremely important		No opinion
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

5. And please indicate how strongly you agree or disagree with each of the following.

	Agree strongly	Agree somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No Opinion
a. Felons have paid their debt to society after they have served their sentences	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Felons have shown that they are incapable of being responsible citizens	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. We have too many national holidays	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. The Electoral College makes many voters irrelevant in the presidential election	1	2	3	4	5		99

6. And how strongly would you favor or oppose each of the following?

	Favor strongly	Favor somewhat	Neither favor nor oppose	Oppose somewhat	Oppose strongly		No opinion
a. Adopting proportional representation for legislative elections	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Making it easier for third party candidates to get on the ballot	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Adopting term limits for members of Congress	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Putting non-partisan commissions in charge of redistricting	1	2	3	4	5		99
e. Requiring all state presidential primaries to be on the same day	1	2	3	4	5		99

Deliberative Polling—Pre-survey

7. And on a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely ineffective, 10 is completely effective, and 5 is exactly in between, how effective do you think each of the following measures would be in increasing choice for voters?

	Completely ineffective					Neither effective nor ineffective					Completely effective		No opinion
a. Adopting proportional representation for legislative elections	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
b. Making it easier for third party candidates to get on the ballot	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. Adopting term limits for members of Congress	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
d. Putting non-partisan commissions in charge of redistricting	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
e. Requiring all state presidential primaries to be on the same day	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

8. And please indicate how strongly you agree or disagree with each of the following.

	Agree strongly	Agree somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No opinion
a. Every voter should have equal say in selecting our presidential candidates, no matter where he or she lives	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Elections in the United States do not currently provide enough choice for voters	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Under proportional representation, the makeup of the government would reflect the vote totals more closely than it does now	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Proportional representation creates unstable, fragmented governments	1	2	3	4	5		99
e. Term limits produce candidates with fresher ideas	1	2	3	4	5		99
f. People should have the right to vote for legislators who are doing a good job no matter how long they have been in office	1	2	3	4	5		99
g. A state that has ten times the number of voters should have ten times the say in selecting our presidential candidates	1	2	3	4	5		99

Deliberative Polling—Pre-survey

9. And how strongly would you favor or oppose each of the following?

	Favor strongly	Favor somewhat	Neither favor nor oppose	Oppose somewhat	Oppose strongly		No opinion
a. Requiring broadcasters to air more public affairs programming	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Providing free TV air time to candidates	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Using public funds to see to it that everyone has access to the internet	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Providing public funding for non-partisan civic education groups to inform voters	1	2	3	4	5		99

10. And on a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely ineffective, 10 is completely effective, and 5 is exactly in-between, how effective do you think each of the following measures would be in increasing political knowledge?

	Completely ineffective					Neither effective nor ineffective					Completely effective		No opinion
a. Requiring broadcasters to air more public affairs programming	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
b. Providing free TV air time to candidates	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. Using public funds to see to it that everyone has access to the internet	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
d. Providing public funding for non-partisan civic education groups to inform voters	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

11. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think it is for American citizens to be informed about politics?

Completely unimportant					Exactly in between					Extremely important		No opinion
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

Deliberative Polling—Pre-survey

12. And please indicate how strongly you agree or disagree with each of the following.

	Agree strongly	Agree somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No Opinion
a. Political candidates should focus more on policy issues in their campaigns	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Political candidates focus too much on attacking other candidates in their campaigns	1	2	3	4	5		99

13. And how strongly would you favor or oppose each of the following?

	Favor strongly	Favor somewhat	Neither favor nor oppose	Oppose somewhat	Oppose strongly		No opinion
a. Keeping public service voluntary	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Keeping public service voluntary, but expanding volunteer public service programs like AmeriCorps and Peace Corps	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Requiring a period of public service from everyone, in either the military or a civilian program	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Requiring a period of military service from everyone	1	2	3	4	5		99

14. And please indicate how strongly you agree or disagree with each of the following.

	Agree Strongly	Agree Somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No opinion
a. Having an all-volunteer military ensures that military personnel are motivated and suited to military life	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Having an all-volunteer military shifts the burden of service on to poor people who have fewer educational and professional opportunities	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Requiring a period of public service would help Americans appreciate the responsibilities as well as the benefits of citizenship	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Mandatory public service runs contrary to the idea of personal liberty	1	2	3	4	5		99
e. Public service obligations should be the same for men and women	1	2	3	4	5		99

Deliberative Polling—Pre-survey

15. And please indicate how strongly you agree or disagree with each of the following.

	Agree strongly	Agree somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No opinion
a. People with views different from mine often have very good reasons for their opinions	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. I consider myself well-qualified to participate in politics	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Public officials care a lot about what people like me think	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Most public policy issues are so complicated that a person like me can't really understand what's going on	1	2	3	4	5		99
e. People like me don't have any say about what the government does	1	2	3	4	5		99
f. Everyone should be involved in politics	1	2	3	4	5		99

Now we are coming to some questions to which not everyone may know the answer. If you come a question which you don't know the answer, just say so and move on to the next one.

16. About how many Americans are prevented from voting because of criminal convictions?

1) 50,000
2) 500,000
3) 5,000,000
4) 15,000,000
99) Couldn't say

17. Does "gerrymandering" reshape districts to...?

1) Increase electoral competition
2) Ensure a majority for one party over another
3) Include independents in the primary process
4) Make them much smaller
99) Couldn't say

18. Approximately what percentage of eligible American voters actually vote in a given presidential general election?

1) 10%
2) 30%
3) 50%
4) 70%
99) Couldn't say

Deliberative Polling—Pre-survey

19. Which of the following countries has a system of "compulsory voting”?

1) Ireland
2) United Kingdom
3) Australia
4) South Korea
99) Couldn't say

20. At present, who must register with the selective service system in the US?

1) Nobody
2) Men between 18 and 25 years old
3) Both men and women between 18 and 25 years old
4) Men and women who receive federal grants for education
99) Couldn't say

21. A candidate is elected President of the United States if he or she...

1) Gets more votes than any other candidate
2) Gets a majority of all the votes cast
3) Gets more Electoral College votes than any other candidate
4) Gets a majority of Electoral College votes
99) Couldn't say

22. How often are congressional districts redrawn?

1) Every 5 years
2) Every 10 years
3) Every 15 years
4) Every 20 years
99) Couldn't say

23. Which two states have traditionally had the earliest presidential primary events for determining their delegates to the parties' national conventions?

1) Nevada and South Carolina
2) Iowa and New Hampshire
3) Indiana and New Mexico
4) Wyoming and Delaware
5) Michigan and Florida
99) Couldn't say

24. In the last 7 days, how many days did you...?

	None	1-2 days	3-4 days	Almost every day
a. Watch the news on TV	1	2	3	4
b. Read a daily newspaper	1	2	3	4
c. Read news sources on the internet	1	2	3	4

Deliberative Polling—Pre-survey

25. On average, how often do you participate in a conversation about public affairs?

1) Practically never
2) About once a month
3) About once a week
4) Several times a week
5) Almost every day

26. Generally speaking, how interested would you say you are in politics in the U.S.?

1) Not at all interested
2) Not very interested
3) Somewhat interested
4) Very interested

Deliberative Polling—Post-survey

1. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think each of the following is to being a good citizen?

	Completely Unimportant					Neither important nor unimportant					Extremely important		No opinion
a. Voting in elections	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
b. Discussing politics with others	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. Being informed about politics and political issues	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. Serving one's country through military or public service	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

2. And how strongly would you favor or oppose each of the following?

	Favor strongly	Favor somewhat	Neither favor nor oppose	Oppose somewhat	Oppose strongly		No Opinion
a. Making Election Day a national holiday	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Allowing Election Day registration	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Allowing felons to vote after they have served their sentences	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Replacing the Electoral College with direct election of the president	1	2	3	4	5		99

3. And on a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely ineffective, 10 is completely effective, and 5 is exactly in-between, how effective do you think each of the following measures would be in increasing voter participation?

	Completely ineffective					Neither effective nor ineffective					Completely effective		No opinion
a. Making Election Day a national holiday	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
b. Allowing Election Day registration	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. Allowing felons to vote after they have served their sentences	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
d. Replacing the Electoral College with direct election of the president	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
e. Fining people who don't vote	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

Deliberative Polling—Post-survey

4. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think it is to increase political participation in the US?

Completely Unimportant					Neither important nor unimportant					Extremely important		No opinion
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

5. And please indicate how strongly you agree or disagree with each of the following.

	Agree strongly	Agree somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No Opinion
a. Felons have paid their debt to society after they have served their sentences	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Felons have shown that they are incapable of being responsible citizens	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. We have too many national holidays	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. The Electoral College makes many voters irrelevant in the presidential election	1	2	3	4	5		99

6. And how strongly would you favor or oppose each of the following?

	Favor strongly	Favor somewhat	Neither favor nor oppose	Oppose somewhat	Oppose strongly		No opinion
a. Adopting proportional representation for legislative elections	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Making it easier for third party candidates to get on the ballot	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Adopting term limits for members of Congress	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Putting non-partisan commissions in charge of redistricting	1	2	3	4	5		99
e. Requiring all state presidential primaries to be on the same day	1	2	3	4	5		99

Deliberative Polling—Post-survey

7. And on a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely ineffective, 10 is completely effective, and 5 is exactly in between, how effective do you think each of the following measures would be in increasing choice for voters?

	Completely ineffective					Neither effective nor ineffective					Completely effective		No opinion
a. Adopting proportional representation for legislative elections	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
b. Making it easier for third party candidates to get on the ballot	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. Adopting term limits for members of Congress	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
d. Putting non-partisan commissions in charge of redistricting	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
e. Requiring all state presidential primaries to be on the same day	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

8. And please indicate how strongly you agree or disagree with each of the following.

	Agree strongly	Agree somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No opinion
a. Every voter should have equal say in selecting our presidential candidates, no matter where he or she lives	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Elections in the United States do not currently provide enough choice for voters	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Under proportional representation, the makeup of the government would reflect the vote totals more closely than it does now	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Proportional representation creates unstable, fragmented governments	1	2	3	4	5		99
e. Term limits produce candidates with fresher ideas	1	2	3	4	5		99
f. People should have the right to vote for legislators who are doing a good job no matter how long they have been in office	1	2	3	4	5		99
g. A state that has ten times the number of voters should have ten times the say in selecting our presidential candidates	1	2	3	4	5		99

Deliberative Polling—Post-survey

9. And how strongly would you favor or oppose each of the following?

	Favor strongly	Favor somewhat	Neither favor nor oppose	Oppose somewhat	Oppose strongly		No opinion
a. Requiring broadcasters to air more public affairs programming	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Providing free TV air time to candidates	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Using public funds to see to it that everyone has access to the internet	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Providing public funding for non-partisan civic education groups to inform voters	1	2	3	4	5		99

10. And on a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely ineffective, 10 is completely effective, and 5 is exactly in-between, how effective do you think each of the following measures would be in increasing political knowledge?

	Completely ineffective					Neither effective nor ineffective					Completely effective		No opinion
a. Requiring broadcasters to air more public affairs programming	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
b. Providing free TV air time to candidates	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. Using public funds to see to it that everyone has access to the internet	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
d. Providing public funding for non-partisan civic education groups to inform voters	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

11. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think it is for American citizens to be informed about politics?

Completely unimportant					Exactly in between					Extremely important		No opinion
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

Deliberative Polling—Post-survey

12. And please indicate how strongly you agree or disagree with each of the following.

	Agree strongly	Agree somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No Opinion
a. Political candidates should focus more on policy issues in their campaigns	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Political candidates focus too much on attacking other candidates in their campaigns	1	2	3	4	5		99

13. And how strongly would you favor or oppose each of the following?

	Favor strongly	Favor somewhat	Neither favor nor oppose	Oppose somewhat	Oppose strongly		No opinion
a. Keeping public service voluntary	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. Keeping public service voluntary, but expanding volunteer public service programs like AmeriCorps and Peace Corps	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Requiring a period of public service from everyone, in either the military or a civilian program	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Requiring a period of military service from everyone	1	2	3	4	5		99

14. And please indicate how strongly you agree or disagree with each of the following.

	Agree Strongly	Agree Somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No opinion
a. Having an all-volunteer military ensures that military personnel are motivated and suited to military life	1	2	3	4	5		99
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c. Requiring a period of public service would help Americans appreciate the responsibilities as well as the benefits of citizenship	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Mandatory public service runs contrary to the idea of personal liberty	1	2	3	4	5		99
e. Public service obligations should be the same for men and women	1	2	3	4	5		99

Deliberative Polling—Post-survey

15. And please indicate how strongly you agree or disagree with each of the following.

	Agree strongly	Agree somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No opinion
a. People with views different from mine often have very good reasons for their opinions	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. I consider myself well-qualified to participate in politics	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. Public officials care a lot about what people like me think	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. Most public policy issues are so complicated that a person like me can't really understand what's going on	1	2	3	4	5		99
e. People like me don't have any say about what the government does	1	2	3	4	5		99
f. Everyone should be involved in politics	1	2	3	4	5		99

Now we are coming to some questions to which not everyone may know the answer. If you come to a question which you don't know the answer, just say so and move on to the next one.

16. About how many Americans are prevented from voting because of criminal convictions?

1) 50,000
2) 500,000
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18. Approximately what percentage of eligible American voters actually vote in a given presidential general election?

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Deliberative Polling—Post-survey

19. Which of the following countries has a system of "compulsory voting”

1) Ireland
2) United Kingdom
3) Australia
4) South Korea
99) Couldn't say

20. At present, who must register with the selective service system in the US?

1) Nobody
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3) Both men and women between 18 and 25 years old
4) Men and women who receive federal grants for education
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1) Gets more votes than any other candidate
2) Gets a majority of all the votes cast
3) Gets more Electoral College votes than any other candidate
4) Gets a majority of Electoral College votes
99) Couldn't say

22. How often are congressional districts redrawn?

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1) Nevada and South Carolina
2) Iowa and New Hampshire
3) Indiana and New Mexico
4) Wyoming and Delaware
5) Michigan and Florida
99) Couldn't say

24. In the last 7 days, how many days did you...?

	None	1-2 days	3-4 days	Almost every day
a. Watch the news on TV	1	2	3	4
b. Read a daily newspaper	1	2	3	4
c. Read news sources on the internet	1	2	3	4

Deliberative Polling—Post-survey

25. On average, how often do you participate in a conversation about public affairs?

1) Practically never
2) About once a month
3) About once a week
4) Several times a week
5) Almost every day

26. Generally speaking, how interested would you say you are in politics in the U.S.?

1) Not at all interested
2) Not very interested
3) Somewhat interested
4) Very interested

Finally, some questions about the discussions you have engaged in over the past few weeks.

27. On a scale of 0 to 10, where 0 is "a waste of time", 10 is "extremely valuable" and 5 is exactly in the middle, how valuable was each of the following in helping you clarify your positions on the issues?

	A waste of time					Exactly in the middle					Extremely valuable		No opinion
a. The online discussions	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
b. The briefing materials	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
c. The text chat forum on the website	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99
d. The event as a whole	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10		99

28. And how strongly would you agree or disagree with each of the following statements?

	Agree strongly	Agree somewhat	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree somewhat	Disagree strongly		No opinion
a. My group moderator provided the opportunity for everyone to participate in the discussion	1	2	3	4	5		99
b. The members of my group participated relatively equally in the discussions	1	2	3	4	5		99
c. My group moderator sometimes tried to influence the group with his or her own views	1	2	3	4	5		99
d. My group moderator tried to make sure that opposing arguments were considered	1	2	3	4	5		99
e. The important aspects of the issues were covered in the group discussions	1	2	3	4	5		99
f. I learned a lot about people very different from me - about what they and their lives are like	1	2	3	4	5		99

Deliberative Polling—Post-survey

29. Before the discussions started each week, how much of the assigned briefing material would you say you had read, on average?

1) Hadn't read or had just glanced at it
2) Had read less than half of it
3) Had read about half of it
4) Had read more than half of it
99) Had read all or nearly all of it

30. And by the end of the last discussion, how much of the briefing materials would you say you had read?

1) Hadn't read or had just glanced at it
2) Had read less than half of it
3) Had read about half of it
4) Had read more than half of it
99) Had read all or nearly all of it

31. Would you say that the briefing material was mostly balanced, or that it clearly favored some positions over others?

1) Mostly balanced
2) Favored some positions over others
99) Don't Know

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Deliberative Democracy in the Classroom Toolkit
Online Survey

If you wish to administer the pre and post-deliberation surveys online, please contact cdd@dp.stanford.edu for a personalized link. This will enable you to see your classroom's results instantaneously, analyze the results with formulated graphs, and access the data in excel sheet format.

For an example of what the online surveys look like, see the links below. Please note that filling in these surveys will not enable you or your class to view the results.

Pre-survey

Post-survey

Alternatively, you can download the pdf versions of the survey and administer them with pencil and paper, and input the data into Excel during class.

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http://cdd.stanford.edu

Deliberative Democracy in the Classroom Toolkit
A ONE PAGE GUIDE FOR MODERATORS OF SMALL GROUP DISCUSSIONS

Before The Discussions:

- Read briefing materials

Beginning Small Group Discussions:

- Start with full attendance
- Silence electronic devices
- Discussion Guidelines:
    - No one is expected to be an expert
    - Everyone's voice counts—respect and listen to each other's opinions
    - No consensus is needed; not everyone needs to agree or disagree, because participants will express their opinions in a confidential questionnaire
- Start discussion with brief introductions: see sample introduction.
- Don't be afraid of silence

During Small Group Discussions:

- Do not express your own opinions/biases
- Do not take hand polls
- Do not add outside information
- Do not correct false statements
    - If the correct answer is in the materials, you can refer them to the materials
- No need for consensus
    - What if my group all agrees? If so, ask your group to consider what people who disagree would say. Use the materials, especially the table, to help guide your participants.
- Ensure balanced opinions
- Encourage everyone to talk
    - If some talk too much, kindly ask them to let others talk
    - If some talk too little, kindly ask them to voice their opinions
- Make sure participants are talking to *each other*, not you
- Less intervention is better, but you must maintain a good climate for deliberation

Sample introduction to begin discussions

My name is _____ and I will be your moderator today. If you have any questions, please feel free to ask me. I would like to start by making sure everyone has his or her materials. Also, please make sure your mobiles are off or on silent mode.

Before we begin, I would like to share some guidelines for discussion. This discussion is an opportunity for everyone to learn and I want to encourage everyone to speak freely. Please respect and listen to each other's opinions and try not to interrupt others. No one is expected to be an expert. Also, no consensus is necessary, not everyone needs to agree or disagree. Each of you will have the opportunity to express your opinions in a confidential questionnaire after the session.

Again, my role is to facilitate your discussion. Let's start by having everyone introduce him or herself. Please tell us your name and something that puzzles you about this topic.

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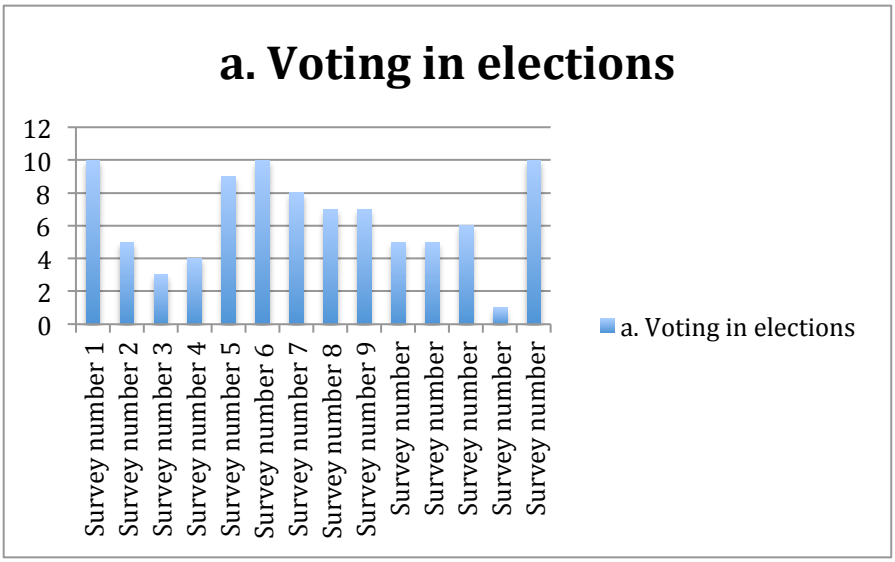
Data Entry Instructions

If you choose to complete the surveys on paper, you can arrange students to enter their own survey data into Microsoft Excel. This way, students can see their opinions from their surveys graphically in Excel. *A template is provided on the CDD website*. Here are some steps you can follow to construct class data.

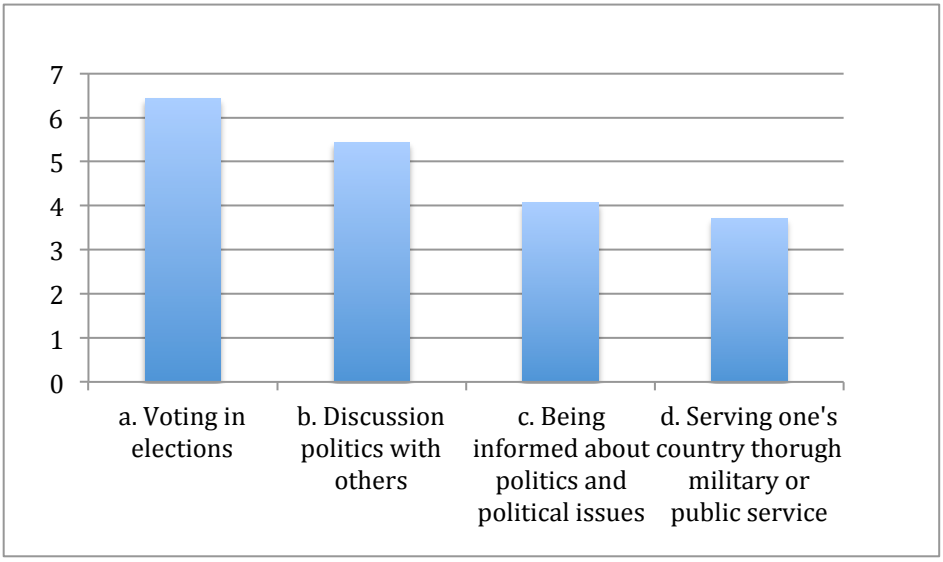
1. Construct class data for individual questions for the presurvey. Have students enter in their responses for each of the questions in the "Presurvey Tab", leaving cells blank if they answered "No Opinion" on a question. Highlight the desired question, and press the "Chart" and "Column" buttons in Excel to construct the graph.

	A	B	C	D	E
1	On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think each of the following is to being a good citizen?	a. Voting in elections	b. Discussion politics with others	c. Being informed about politics and political issues	d. Serving one's country thorugh military or public service
2	Survey number 1	10	9	3	1
3	Survey number 2	5	4	3	2
4	Survey number 3	3	8	4	4
5	Survey number 4	4	2	2	3
6	Survey number 5	9	1	5	10
7	Survey number 6	10	5	7	8
8	Survey number 7	8	2	2	2
9	Survey number 8	7	4	5	3
10	Survey number 9	7	9	1	3
11	Survey number 10	5	8	5	1
12	Survey number 11	5	8	6	6
13	Survey number 12	6	2	2	4
14	Survey number 13	1	5	7	2
15	Survey number 14	10	9	5	3
16	Average	6.42857143	5.42857143	4.07142857	3.714285714

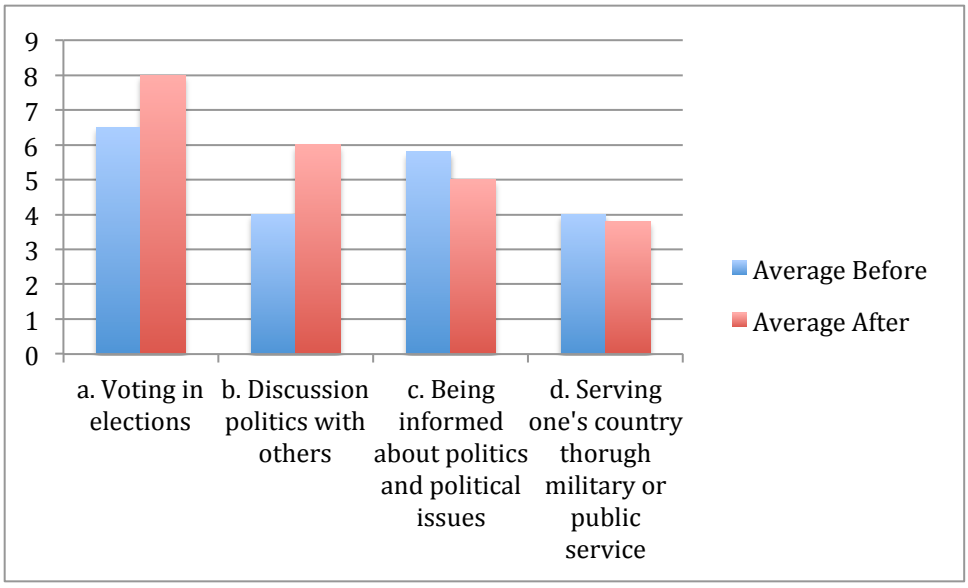


2. Construct the data for class averages. This can be done after each student has input his/her data. Excel can automatically calculate averages, using the formula =AVERAGE(cell1:cell2). Then highlight the desired questions, and construct the graph.

	A	B	C	D	E
1	1. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think each of the following is to being a good citizen?	a. Voting in elections	b. Discussion politics with others	c. Being informed about politics and political issues	d. Serving one's country thorugh military or public service
2	Survey number 1	10	9	3	1
3	Survey number 2	5	4	3	2
4	Survey number 3	3	8	4	4
5	Survey number 4	4	2	2	3
6	Survey number 5	9	1	5	10
7	Survey number 6	10	5	7	8
8	Survey number 7	8	2	2	2
9	Survey number 8	7	4	5	3
10	Survey number 9	7	9	1	3
11	Survey number 10	5	8	5	1
12	Survey number 11	5	8	6	6
13	Survey number 12	6	2	2	4
14	Survey number 13	1	5	7	2
15	Survey number 14	10	9	5	3
16	Average	6.428571429	5.428571429	4.071428571	3.714285714



3. Repeat for the postsurvey results, in the “Postsurvey” tab, or create your own.

4. Compare averages before and after deliberation. Go to the Comparison tab, or create your own. Input the averages found in Step 2 and Step 3 for before and after. Highlight the desired questions, and construct the graphs.

	A	B	C
1	On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is completely unimportant, 10 is extremely important, and 5 is exactly in between, how important do you think each of the following is to being a good citizen?	Average Before	Average After
2	a. Voting in elections	6.5	8
3	b. Discussion politics with others	4	6
4	c. Being informed about politics and political issues	5.8	5
5	d. Serving one's country thorugh military or public service	4	3.8
6